

The Second-Hand Spellbook

A Cozy Fantasy Novel

by Maren Ashcroft

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The Ferry in October

The ferry to Saltmarch had been old when Maren Vessel left, and it was the same ferry.

She recognised it from the harbour at Fenn, before she had even read the board: the particular rust-coloured streak below the rail on the port side, shaped a bit like a rabbit if you were nine and bored and had a whole crossing to fill. Somebody had painted over it at some point. It had come back through.

She stood on the deck for the whole forty minutes, because sitting inside meant looking at the other seven passengers, and looking at the other seven passengers meant that one of them might turn out to know her.

Nobody did. It had been eleven years, and Saltmarch was a town that let you go if you insisted.

The crossing was flat and grey and smelled of diesel and cold salt. Gulls followed them out of Fenn for a while and then thought better of it. Maren kept both hands on the rail and watched the mainland become a line and then a suggestion, and she thought, with the clarity that arrives when you are too tired to lie to yourself: *I could have come at Easter. She asked me at Easter.*

The letter had come in July. It had been short, because Ilse's letters were always short, and it had said that the roof over the back room needed doing and that the Hallow girl had had twins, and at the bottom, in the same handwriting, no larger and no smaller: *Come in the summer if you can manage it. I would like to show you where things are.*

Maren had written back that she would try to come in the autumn. She had meant it at the time, in the way you mean a thing you have not yet had to do.

Ilse had died on the fourteenth of September, in her own bed, at eighty-nine, and the solicitor in Fenn had telephoned on the sixteenth, and here was Maren on the twelfth of October with a rucksack and a laptop bag and a folder of papers she had not read properly, arriving to show herself where things were.

Saltmarch came up out of the water the way it always had, all at once, as though it had been waiting behind the headland to be surprising.

It was not a pretty town, exactly. It was a working harbour with a town leaning over it, three streets deep, the houses rendered in colours that had been chosen a hundred years ago to be visible in fog: mustard, oxblood, a green like the inside of a bottle. The church tower was too big for the town. The chip shop had a new sign. The old net loft on the east pier had a hole in the roof that Maren was almost certain had been there when she was seventeen.

The ferry bumped the fenders twice and settled, and a boy of about twenty threw a rope with the confidence of somebody whose father had thrown that rope, and Maren picked up her bag and went down the ramp into the town she had spent eleven years being from rather than in.

The shop was on Quay Street, second from the corner.

She stopped about thirty feet short of it, which she had not planned to do, and stood in the middle of the pavement with her rucksack on one shoulder while a woman with a pushchair went around her without comment.

VESSEL & DAUGHTER, said the board over the window. SECOND-HAND BOOKS.

There had not been a daughter for sixty years. Ilse's father had painted that board when Ilse was eleven and had put her in it because she had asked him to, and Ilse had never had a daughter of her own, and had never repainted the board, and had once told Maren, in the back room, over tea, with no particular emphasis: *I like that it is wrong. It reminds me that a shop is a promise you make to somebody who has not turned up yet.*

The window was exactly as Maren remembered. The same green paint, blistering in the same three places. The same brass handle worn pale on the underside where forty years of hands had pulled it.

Taped inside the glass, at eye level, in blue biro on the back of a receipt, in careful capitals:

CLOSED. A DEATH IN THE FAMILY.
BACK WHEN THERE IS SOMEBODY TO OPEN IT.

Maren stood and read it twice.

She did not recognise the handwriting, but she recognised the phrasing, which was Saltmarch to the bone: not *closed until further notice*, not *closed due to bereavement*, but a plain flat statement of the situation and a condition for its ending. Somebody had taped that up four weeks ago and gone home.

She got the keys out of her coat pocket. There were three on the ring, and the solicitor had labelled none of them, and it took her two tries.

The bell over the door was the same bell.

That was the thing that did it, in the end. Not the board and not the window and not the smell, which was the smell of every second-hand bookshop that has ever existed, dust and old glue and slightly damp paper and, underneath, faintly, the coal-tar soap Ilse had used for sixty years. It was the bell. Two notes, the second one flat, a small stupid apologetic sound that had annoyed Maren enormously when she was fifteen and had had to hear it four hundred times a day.

She stood in the doorway with her hand still on the handle and let it finish ringing.

Then she came in and put her bag down on the floor and looked at the shop.

It was smaller than she remembered, which she had expected, and more crowded, which she had not. Ilse had gone on buying. There were books stacked flat on top of the shelved books, and books in banana boxes along the base of the counter, and a run of orange Penguins on the windowsill that had faded to the colour of weak tea on the side facing the glass.

The counter had the same brass bell, the same tin of pencils, the same ledger. The chair behind it had a cushion that Maren did not recognise, a new one, worn into the shape of somebody.

Everything was clean. That was the strange part. Everything was dusted and swept and the waste basket was empty and the little sink in the back had been scoured, and somebody had turned the water off at the stopcock and left a note on the counter that said WATER OFF AT STOPCOCK, UNDER SINK, TURN LEFT in the same blue biro capitals as the sign in the window.

Maren picked up the note and held it.

Somebody had come in here, after, and had cleaned a dead woman's shop, and had thought about the pipes freezing, and had written down where the stopcock was for whoever came next, and had not left a name.

She put the note in her pocket. She did not entirely know why.

She did the practical things, because doing practical things was the only thing she was reliably good at.

She found the stopcock and turned it left and listened to the pipes shudder and settle. She found the fuse box in the cupboard under the stairs and pushed the big switch up and the shop lights came on, four bulbs in green enamel shades, one of them dead. She opened the back door into the yard and let the cold in for a while to move the air.

She did not go upstairs. She was aware of not going upstairs, and of the small cowardice of it, and she went on not going upstairs for another hour.

Instead she stood at the counter and opened the ledger, because that was work, and work was safe.

It was a stock book, not accounts. Ilse's hand, small and upright and entirely unchanged from the earliest entries to the last: date, description, what she had paid, where it had come from. *House clearance, Thorn Lane, 3 boxes, £20.* *Mrs Odell, 11 vols garden, gift.* *Fenn market, box of Everyman, £8, four water-damaged.*

The last entry was the fourth of September, ten days before she died. *Bril boy, comics, no charge. Told him to bring them back when he has finished so somebody else can have them.*

Maren read that one twice as well.

Then she closed the ledger and stood with her hand flat on the cover and looked down the length of the shop at the shelves going back into the dimness of the far wall, floor to ceiling, all of them full.

At the very top, above the reach of the highest shelf that a person could get to standing up, there was one more run of books. It went the whole width of the back wall, and there was a wooden ladder on a rail beneath it, and even in the poor light Maren could see that the spines up there were wrong.

Not damaged. Not old, particularly.

Blank. Not one of them had a title on the spine.

She looked at it for a while, from the counter, with her hand still on the ledger.

Then the bell over the door went, two notes, the second one flat, and a voice she did not know said, "You'll be Maren, then. I'm sorry about your aunt. She was a difficult woman and I liked her very much."

The Woman Who Wrote the Sign

The woman in the doorway was somewhere in her seventies and dressed for weather that had not arrived yet.

She had a waxed jacket on over what looked like three jumpers, and a canvas bag, and the specific unhurried expression of a person who has decided to come in and will not be leaving until she has finished. Her hair was white and cut short and slightly wrong on one side, as though she did it herself with the good scissors.

"Ines Hallow," she said. "I did your window."

"You wrote the sign."

"I wrote the sign and I did the pipes and I emptied her bin, because the alternative was standing in my kitchen thinking about it." Ines put the canvas bag on the counter without being asked. "There's a fruit loaf in there. Don't thank me, I made two. How was the crossing?"

"Flat."

"It usually is in October. It's November you want to avoid." She was looking around the shop as she spoke, not at Maren, taking inventory in the way people do in a room they have known for decades. "She left it tidy. She was tidy right to the end, which I found irritating, personally. I'd have liked her to be a bit of a mess at the finish. Something to disapprove of."

Maren found she had no idea what to say to that.

"You'll want to know why nobody rang you before the fourteenth," Ines said.

"No."

"Yes you will, at about two in the morning, so I'll tell you now and save you the trouble. She wasn't ill. She was eighty-nine and then she was tired and then she was eighty-nine and dead, and there were four days in the middle when somebody might

have rung somebody, and in those four days she said she didn't want a fuss." Ines turned round at last and looked at her directly. She had very pale eyes, the colour of the harbour on a clear day. "She meant it. I want you to know she meant it, because you will spend a certain amount of time deciding she was being brave for your benefit, and she wasn't. She was being stubborn for her own. It was her best quality."

Maren put her hand flat on the counter.

"Thank you," she said, and meant it, and was surprised.

"Right." Ines picked up her bag, took the fruit loaf out, and put the loaf back on the counter, which struck Maren as a very deliberate way of leaving something. "Are you selling it?"

"I don't know."

"That's a better answer than yes." She went to the door and the bell did its two notes. "There's a man called Quay in the tea shop next door who will be in tomorrow with bread, because he cannot help himself. And there'll be a notice going up from the council this week that you're not going to like. Read it properly before anyone tells you what it says."

"What notice?"

But Ines Hallow had a way of leaving that did not permit questions, and the door had already shut.

She did two hours of work before she went up, at the counter, on the laptop, because there was a manual for a heat exchanger due on Friday and because the world outside Saltmarch had not been informed of any of this.

It was the ordinary part of her life and she did it in the ordinary way: three hundred and forty pages of somebody else's English, checking that every cross-reference pointed where it claimed to, that the numbering did not skip, that a warning on page ninety was the same warning on page two hundred and eleven.

She had been doing it for twelve years and was very good at it, and she had never once managed to explain at a party what it actually consisted of, because what it actually consisted of was holding a large document in your head and waiting for the place where it stopped agreeing with itself.

At about half five she found one. A torque figure given in two units in two places, and the conversion wrong by a factor that would not hurt anybody but would cost some fitter in Rotterdam a morning. She wrote the query and flagged it

and felt the small clean satisfaction that was, she was aware, the entire reason she had never looked for a different job.

Then she closed the laptop and looked up and remembered where she was.

That was the first time it happened, and it happened perhaps two hundred times over the following months: two hours inside a document, and then a shop, arriving all at once, like a room you have walked into in the dark.

Maren went upstairs at half past six, because at half past six it got dark and the alternative was standing in a shop with the lights on where anybody walking past on Quay Street could look in at her.

The flat above the shop was three rooms and a bathroom, and it had not been altered since 1974, and Maren had slept in the small back room for six summers between the ages of nine and fifteen.

She went into that room first, which was a mistake and she knew it was a mistake while she was doing it.

Ilse had turned it into a store room, which was sensible, and there were boxes of stock stacked to the window sill, which was also sensible, and the bed was still there under a dust sheet, which was not sensible at all, because a woman who needs storage space does not keep a single bed she has no use for.

Maren stood in the doorway with her hand on the light switch for a while.

Then she went and made up the bed in the other room, the front one, which had been Ilse's, and which had clean sheets on it already, folded at the end of the mattress in a square, with a note on top in blue biro capitals: SHE'D HAVE WANTED THE FRONT ROOM. IT'S WARMER. I.H.

Maren sat down on the edge of the bed and laughed, once, and then did not laugh, and sat there for about ten minutes in her coat.

She could not sleep, which she had expected, so at eleven she went back down.

The shop at night was better than the shop in the day. The four bulbs in their green shades made three overlapping pools and left the rest in a brown dimness, and the window went black and stopped being a thing that people could look through and became a mirror instead, and the whole room got smaller and closer and more like the inside of something.

Maren made tea on the little ring in the back, using the mug that was on the draining board, and then stood in the middle of the shop floor with it and looked up at the top shelf.

She had been aware of that shelf all afternoon, in the way you are aware of a person standing at the edge of a room.

It ran the full width of the back wall, above the ordinary shelves, about ten feet up. There was a wooden ladder on a brass rail, the proper kind that slides, and it had been oiled recently enough that when she pushed it, it moved.

She went up.

The books were the wrong books.

That was the only way she could put it, then, standing on the fourth rung with her head at the level of the shelf and a torch on her phone. They were not remarkable. Cloth boards, mostly, various sizes, various ages, the sort of stock any second-hand shop accumulates. Two of them had marbled paper. One was clearly a school prize book from the twenties with the plate torn out.

But not one of them had a title on the spine.

Not faded. Not rubbed away. There was no lettering there at all, and no gilt, and no ghost of where gilt had been, on any of the forty-odd books along that shelf, and Maren had spent enough time around old books to know that this does not happen by accident to forty books in a row.

She took one out.

It came away easily. It was heavier than it looked, the way books always are, and the boards were dark green cloth with a blind-stamped border, and there was no title on the front either, and no half-title inside, and no title page.

The pages were blank.

All of them. She went through the whole book on the ladder with the torch in her teeth, and it was a properly bound book, sewn, with endpapers and a ribbon, and there was not one mark on any of the two hundred and something pages.

She put it back and took down the next one.

Blank.

The third one had a price pencilled inside the front cover, and Maren's chest did something odd before she looked at it properly and saw that it was not a price. It was a date. *11.iv.63.* And under it, in the same small upright hand she had been reading in the stock ledger all afternoon, three words:

M. Odell. Returned.

She stood on the ladder for a long moment in the dark shop with a blank book in her hand.

Then she went back down, carefully, and put it on the counter, and looked at it, and did not open it again.

She thought: forty books with no titles and no text, on a shelf nobody can reach without a ladder, in a shop where every other item is priced in pencil on the top right corner of the front endpaper.

She thought: she kept a stock book for forty years and wrote down a twenty-pound box of house clearance, and she did not write these down anywhere.

And then, because she was very tired and because it was midnight and because the bell over the door had been the same bell, she thought, quite clearly, in Ilse's voice:

A shop is a promise you make to somebody who has not turned up yet.

Maren turned off three of the four lights and left the one over the counter on, which she told herself was for the look of the thing from the street, and went up to bed.

She did not sleep for a long time, and when she did she dreamed about the ladder, and in the dream it was much longer.

The Man From the Tea Shop

Tobias Quay arrived at ten past nine with bread, exactly as advertised.

He was a wide, unhurried man of about forty in an apron, with forearms that suggested a lot of dough had passed through his hands, and he did not knock. He came in through the connecting door in the back wall that Maren had assumed was a cupboard.

"That's a door," she said.

"That's a door." He put a paper bag on the counter. "Sorry. Nineteen years I've been coming through it and I've stopped thinking of it as a wall. There's a bolt on your side, it's the black one, and if you shoot it I won't be offended and I'll knock at the front like a customer."

"You share a chimney breast?"

"We share a chimney breast, a damp problem, and a rat we've both named. Yours is called Ilse's rat and mine is called Quay's rat and we've never established whether it's the same rat." He looked at her properly for the first time, and there was nothing in it but ordinary friendliness, which Maren had not been braced for and which was consequently harder to deal with. "Tobias. Tea shop. I'm very sorry."

"Thank you."

"She used to come through at four for a pot and complain about a customer, and then at about ten past four she'd say the customer had actually been perfectly all right, and then she'd go back." He said it easily, without weight. "I've been doing four o'clock on my own for a month and it's a stupid amount to miss a person for."

Maren discovered she had sat down on the chair behind the counter, on the cushion worn into the shape of somebody.

"What's in the bag?" she said.

"Yesterday's, which is the good stuff, and a scone which is today's and therefore has nothing wrong with it. Don't be polite about the scone, if you don't want it I'll eat it in front of you."

He stayed twenty minutes and made himself useful in the way of a man who has decided not to ask any of the questions he wants to ask.

He showed her which of the four bulbs needed the odd fitting and where Ilse kept the spares. He told her the boiler had to be lit with a match and not with the button, and that the button was a lie, and had been a lie since 2019. He mentioned, in passing and without pressure, that the shop had not been open since the fourth of September and that people had noticed.

"Noticed how?"

"Noticed as in three people have asked me when it's opening and one of them has asked twice." Tobias leaned on the counter. "You should understand what you've got here. It's not a bookshop, exactly. Or it is, but that's not the main function. In a town this size in October there's the pub, which is not for everybody, and the church hall on a Tuesday, which is definitely not for everybody, and this. This is where people come and stand about for twenty minutes and say nothing much and go home feeling better. Your aunt priced things at two pounds fifty for forty years for exactly that reason."

"That's not a business."

"No," he agreed, cheerfully. "It's why the roof's like that."

"How did she live?"

"Badly, and on purpose." Tobias said it with real affection. "She owned the freehold outright, she had a state pension, and her outgoings were coal, tea, and about forty pounds a month of stock she mostly gave away. I did her accounts for four years because she asked me to and then she stopped asking, and I've a suspicion that was because I kept telling her what they said."

"Which was?"

"That in the good years she cleared eleven hundred pounds and in the bad ones she cleared nothing, and that if she'd shut this and let it as a holiday flat she'd have had two thousand a month without getting out of bed." He shrugged. "I told her that in, I want to say, 2019. She listened to the whole thing very politely and then she said, *and who would Ines talk to.*"

Maren looked at the shelves going back into the dim end of the shop.

"That's not an answer," she said.

"No. It's the answer to a different question that she'd decided was the one that mattered." Tobias picked up the empty paper bag and folded it, which she would learn was a thing he did with his hands when he was choosing what to say. "I'm not going to tell you what to do with this building. It isn't mine and I've got my own notice to worry about. But you should know that if you shut it, nothing replaces it. There isn't a second one. That's the whole of what I've got to say on the subject and I'll not say it twice."

Maren looked at the ceiling, which had a brown bloom in the back corner about the size of a dinner plate.

"How bad?"

"Back room only, and it's the flashing, not the slates. Six hundred if you get Dinny Coll to do it and he does it properly, four hundred if you get his nephew and he does it twice." He straightened up. "Which brings me to the thing I came to say, and then I'll go and let you get on."

"Ines said there'd be a notice."

"Ines is ahead of the council, which is her hobby." He was not smiling now, though his face had not really changed. "There's a proposal going to full council on the thirtieth of November for a new ferry terminal. Not the pier. The pier stays. A terminal building, with a waiting room and an office and a car deck, on the harbour side of Quay Street."

Maren waited.

"Quay Street numbers one to seven," said Tobias.

"We're number two."

"We're number two and I'm number four." He said it without drama, which somehow made it worse. "It's a compulsory purchase in principle, at district valuation. There's a consultation, which runs to the fourteenth of November, and there's an open meeting, and then there's a vote, and I have been to enough of these to tell you honestly that the consultation is a form of politeness."

"That's six weeks."

"Seven and a bit. It's been coming for two years, in the way things come here, which is that everybody talks about it and nobody believes it and then there's a notice on a lamp post."

Maren found she was gripping the edge of the counter.

"Did she know?"

Tobias hesitated for the first time.

"She knew," he said. "She went to the September committee, which was the second, and she stood up and spoke for four minutes, and I've been told it was very good and very rude. And then she came back and made a pot of tea and said she'd be dead before it mattered." He looked at the counter. "Which was true, as it turns out. She was often annoyingly correct about things."

When he had gone back through the door that was a door, Maren stood in the middle of her aunt's shop and did the arithmetic that she had come to Saltmarch specifically to do.

The building was hers, freehold, with a probate valuation that the solicitor's letter had put at a figure she had read three times on the train. A compulsory purchase at district valuation would be, if anything, slightly more than that. She had come here to sell. Selling to the council was, in the crudest possible reading, easier than selling to a person, because the council could not change its mind and could not ask about the roof.

She could be back in her flat by the first week of November with the whole thing settled and a cheque in the post by spring.

She stood there and let herself think that all the way through to the end, honestly, because she had spent eleven years being a person who was honest about her own motives and it was too late to stop.

Then she looked up at the shelf.

Forty books with nothing on the spines. One of them with a date in it from 1963 and a name and the single word *Returned*.

"That's not a reason," she said out loud, to the empty shop, and was slightly appalled at herself.

The bell over the door went, two notes, the second one flat.

A woman of about thirty came in with a small child on her hip, stopped dead, and said, "Oh. Oh, I'm sorry, I saw the light on and I thought — " and then stopped again, and her face did something complicated. "You're never Maren."

"I am, though."

"Trine Bril. I was two years under you at the school." She shifted the child. "I'm sorry about Ilse. God. I'm sorry, I've come in and the first thing I've done is stand here with my mouth open."

"It's all right."

"It's only that my Cato has had a stack of her comics since the start of the month and I've been carrying them about in the car for three weeks not knowing what to do with them, because you can't post comics back to a dead woman, can you." She laughed, and it went slightly wrong at the end. "Are you open?"

Maren looked at the woman, and at the child, and at the door standing open behind them with the cold coming in off the harbour, and at the sign on the inside of the glass that said BACK WHEN THERE IS SOMEBODY TO OPEN IT.

"Not officially," she said.

"Right. No. Of course."

"But you can bring the comics in."

Forty Years and Then Nothing

The comics came back in a supermarket bag for life, and Cato Bril came with them.

She was twelve, and she had the particular stiffness of a child who has been told in the car that she is to be polite and not to mention anything, and she stood by the door with her hands in her sleeves and looked at the floor.

"Say hello, Cato."

"Hello."

"She's not usually like this."

"I'm exactly usually like this," said Cato, to the floor.

Maren took the bag and put it on the counter and looked inside without making a performance of it. Forty-odd comics, in order, each one flat and uncreased, with a strip of paper torn from a notebook laid inside the front cover of the top one. On the strip, in blue biro, not Ilse's hand and not Ines's: *sorry about the corner of no. 12 it was already like that when I got it but I want to say anyway.*

Maren read it, and put it back exactly where it had been, and did not say anything about it, and this turned out to be the correct decision, because Cato looked up.

"Are you keeping it open?"

"Cato."

"It's a fair question," said Maren.

"It's a rude question when the lady's aunt has just — "

"It isn't," Maren said. "It's the only question." She put the bag under the counter. "I don't know yet. I've been here one day."

Cato considered this with the seriousness of somebody who has been given a real answer and was not expecting one.

"She let me have them for nothing," she said, "but I had to bring them back so somebody else could have them, and I've brought them back, so that's done."

"That's done," Maren agreed.

"So can I have some more."

They went at about eleven, with four more comics and a firm arrangement about their return, and Maren locked the door behind them and did not turn the sign round, and then stood with her back against the door and thought: *right. That's how it happens. That is exactly how it happens.*

Then she went and got the ledgers out.

There were nine of them, in the cupboard under the stairs, in a stack, oldest at the bottom. Stock books, all the same pattern, bought from the same stationer in Fenn for sixty years, and she took them all up to the counter and worked through them in order with a mug of tea going cold at her elbow.

It took two hours and it was, she admitted to herself, a very enjoyable two hours, in the way that other people's paperwork is enjoyable when you have no responsibility for it.

Ilse had been a good bookseller and a poor businesswoman and a magnificent recorder of small facts. There were forty years of house clearances and market boxes and gifts and swaps. There were opinions in the margins, occasionally: *nice set, foxed, will keep.* *Not worth it. Bought anyway, he needed the money.* *Third copy of this. Why.*

And then, in the seventh ledger, at the back, after the last stock entry, there were nine more pages that were not stock at all.

They were ruled into four columns by hand, in pencil, with a ruler.

The first column was a date. The second was a name. The third was a short phrase. The fourth was another short phrase, in slightly smaller writing, and Maren looked at the fourth column for a long time before she understood that she did not understand it.

14.ii.61 / E. Coll / the smell of the sheds at Braer / a hymn tune
3.v.61 / Mrs Odell / her mother's voice saying grace / the word 'threshold'
19.vi.61 / J. Vane / the taste of the yellow apples / the road out to Tolm

It went on. Page after page. Four or five a year at first, then more.

Maren, who proofread technical documentation for a living and had a professional relationship with columns, read it the way she read everything, which was to work out what the columns were before deciding what they meant.

Column one: when. Column two: who. Column three: something specific and sensory and gone. Column four: also something specific, also gone, but with no name attached to it.

She turned the pages.

8.i.74 / H. Bril / the way his father laughed / the second verse of anything

22.x.81 / Ines H. / her mother's hand on the back of her neck / the name of the cove past Skerry Point

4.iii.90 / P. Vane / nothing, refused / nothing

That one stopped her. *Refused*, and then the fourth column filled in with the same word, which meant, if the columns meant what they seemed to mean, that when Ilse had not given something away she had also not lost anything.

Maren sat back.

She got up and walked to the far end of the shop and came back, because it was that or sit still and think, and then she pulled the ladder along its rail and went up four rungs and took down the green book with *M. Odell. Returned.* pencilled inside the cover, and brought it to the counter and put it beside the ledger.

*3.v.61 / Mrs Odell / her mother's voice saying grace / the word 'threshold'.

She turned to the front of the ledger's four-column pages and found the heading, which she had skipped past twice because it was one word and she had assumed it was a label for the whole book.

It said: LENT.

She read all nine pages twice, and the second time she read them as a document rather than as a story, which was the only way she knew how to get anything out of anything.

Documents have shapes. This one had three.

The first shape was the rate. Four or five entries a year through the sixties, eight or nine through the seventies, and then from about 1984 it went up and stayed up: fifteen, eighteen, twenty-one in 1991. Whatever this was, Ilse Vessel had done more of it as she got older, not less, right up to the point where she had stopped entirely.

The second shape was the names. There were two hundred and nine entries and perhaps sixty surnames, and the same ones came round and round: Coll, Bril, Odell,

Hallow, Vane, Skerrit, Quay. Nobody appeared twice in the same year. A few appeared once in a decade for four decades, which meant that somewhere in this town there were people in their eighties who had been coming to that back room since they were thirty and had never mentioned it to anybody, including, apparently, each other.

The third shape was in the handwriting, and it was the one that made Maren put the pencil down.

The entries from 1961 were written in the hand she knew from the stock books: small, upright, entirely regular, the writing of a woman who had been taught to write in 1948 and had seen no reason to revise the decision.

The entries from 2013 and 2014 were the same hand in every particular except size. They had got bigger. Not shaky. Bigger, the way handwriting gets when somebody is having to concentrate on it.

And on the eighth page, in the margin beside an entry from March 2015, there was a note that was not part of any column at all, written small and fast and at a slight angle, as though it had been put there in a hurry and not meant to be kept.

Ask Ines what it was called. Do not write it here. If you write it here you will only be reading it, and that is not the same thing.

Maren read that four times.

Then she went and put the kettle on, and stood in the back room with her arms folded, and did not think about anything in particular for about six minutes, which was as close to a rest as she had had since the ferry.

The last entry was on the ninth page.

Maren turned to it and looked at the date and did the arithmetic twice, because she had not expected to have a personal stake in a column of pencil.

29.viii.15 / I.V. / my sister's face / my sister's face

Both columns. The same words in both columns. The third and the fourth, filled in with the same three words in a hand that was recognisably Ilse's and recognisably not steady.

And then nothing. Nine pages of forty-four years, and then half an inch of blank ruled paper, and then the end of the book.

The twenty-ninth of August, 2015.

Eleven years, one month and fourteen days ago. Two weeks before Maren had finished her degree and taken a job in Fenn and then a job further off, and had

stopped coming in the summers, and had begun the long quiet business of being from Saltmarch rather than in it.

She had never once wondered what her aunt had done with the time.

Maren sat in the shop with the ledger open and the blank green book beside it and the harbour going about its afternoon behind the window, and for the first time since the solicitor's telephone call in September she felt something arrive that was not tiredness and was not guilt.

It was the other thing. The bad one. The one she had built an entire orderly adult life to avoid.

She was curious.

A Book From the Shelf, The Way She Did It

Ines Hallow came back on the Thursday, in the same waxed jacket, with a different bag.

"You've opened," she said.

"I haven't opened."

"There are two children in the corner reading on the floor and a man from the harbour board looking at your maps."

Maren, who had turned the sign round on Tuesday at about half past ten without making a decision about it, said nothing.

"Mm," said Ines, and went and looked at the maps herself for a while, and waited until the harbour board man had bought a Ward Lock guide to the north coast for three pounds and the children had been collected, and the shop was empty.

Then she came to the counter and put both hands on it.

"I'd like a book from the shelf," she said. "The way your aunt did it."

The shop was very quiet. Somewhere behind the wall Tobias dropped something metal and swore.

"Which shelf," said Maren.

"Don't."

"I'm asking which shelf."

"You've had the ladder out. There's oil on the rail and there wasn't in September, because I oiled it in September and I know what I left." Ines's pale eyes were entirely steady. "You've been up. You've had them down. You've found the ledger,

because it's in the seventh book and anybody who reads nine ledgers finds it. So don't make me stand here and be delicate about it, because I'm seventy-four and I've been being delicate about it since 1981."

Maren put down the pencil she had been holding.

"They're blank," she said.

"Yes."

"Every one of them. No title, no text, nothing. They're not books, they're bound paper."

"Yes."

"Then what exactly are you asking me for?"

And Ines Hallow, who had cleaned a dead woman's shop and written a sign in blue biro and left sheets folded in a square on a bed, said, "I'm asking you to hand me one and let me sit down with it for twenty minutes. That's the whole of it. That's all she ever did."

Maren did not do it immediately.

She stood there for what felt like a long time and was probably eight seconds, and she went through, at speed, all of the reasonable positions available to her: that this was a lonely old woman with a ritual attached to a dead friend, that indulging it was unkind, that refusing it was crueller, that she herself had been in the town three days and had no standing to decide what was and was not indulged here.

And under all of that, running quietly, the thing she had recognised at the counter on Tuesday afternoon with a ledger open in front of her.

She wanted to see what happened.

"Sit in the back," she said. "There's the chair by the stove. I'm not having you on a stool at seventy-four."

"I'm perfectly all right on a stool."

"I'm sure you are."

She went up the ladder.

"Which one?" she called down.

"She never asked me that."

"How did she choose?"

There was a pause underneath her.

"She used to put her hand flat on the shelf," said Ines, "and go along it, and stop. And I asked her once what she was feeling for and she said she wasn't feeling for anything, she was giving herself time to change her mind."

Maren stood on the fourth rung with the torch off and the afternoon light coming grey along the shelf, and put her hand flat on the row of blank spines, and went along it.

She did not feel anything. There was nothing to feel: cloth, board, the small give of a book that is not quite tight against its neighbour, dust on the top edges which she would have to do something about.

She stopped about two thirds of the way along, at a squat brown one with a blind-stamped panel.

She would not have been able to say why she stopped there, and it bothered her later, and it went on bothering her for a long time.

Ines sat in the chair by the stove with the brown book closed on her knee and both hands on top of it, like a woman in a waiting room.

"Do you open it?" said Maren, from the doorway.

"You open it."

"It's blank."

"I know what it is." Ines looked up. "Go and mind your shop, Maren. It doesn't work with somebody watching, and it isn't a performance, and you'll have your turn."

So Maren went and minded her shop.

She sold a Georgette Heyer and a road atlas from 1998 to a woman who wanted it specifically because it was from 1998. She priced a box of gardening books at two pounds fifty each, because two pounds fifty was apparently what happened in this building. She looked at the ceiling stain twice.

She did not look through the doorway into the back room, and the effort of not doing it was considerable, and she was extremely aware of the clock over the door, which had been slow by four minutes for as long as she could remember and had not been corrected.

At eleven minutes she gave up pretending and went quietly up the ladder instead, which she told herself was not the same as looking.

She wanted to see the others.

She took down four in a row, working left, and opened each one on the top of the ladder with the afternoon coming in grey behind her. Blank. Blank. Blank. The fourth had two words pencilled inside the front board in the small upright hand, *E. Coll. Returned.*, and under it, much fainter, as though written years later with a different pencil, a single line:

He came back in '89 and I said no. He took it well.

Maren sat down on the ladder, which is not a thing ladders are for.

She had assumed, without examining the assumption, that the shelf was a kindness Ilse had handed out to whoever asked. But there was a *no* in it. Somewhere in 1989 a man had come into this shop and asked for something and been refused, and had taken it well, and Ilse had thought that worth writing down eleven feet above her own head where nobody would ever read it.

Which meant there had been a rule.

Which meant that somewhere, in a building Maren had inherited entire, there was a woman's forty-year practice of when to say yes and when to say no, and no version of it survived except in pencil, in fragments, in books that nobody could reach without a ladder.

She put all four back, in order, exactly where they had been.

At nineteen minutes she heard a sound from the back room.

It was not distress. She was quite certain about that, then and afterwards. It was a single short intake of breath, the sort you make when you step off a kerb you did not know was there.

Maren stood absolutely still behind the counter with a pencil in her hand.

At twenty-three minutes Ines Hallow came out of the back room with the brown book held against her chest with both arms, the way you hold something in a wind.

Her face was wet. She had made no attempt to do anything about it.

"Here," she said, and held the book out, and her voice was perfectly ordinary, which was somehow the worst part. "Put it back where it was. Not just on the shelf. Where it was."

Maren took it.

"Ines — "

"Two thirds along, brown, next to the one with the marbled boards." Ines was already doing up her jacket. "She always put them back exactly. I never asked why and now I can't, so we'll both do it her way and be grateful."

"What happened?"

Ines stopped at the door with her hand on the brass.

"My mother used to sing me something," she said. "When I was small. Before the war, so I'd have been four, five. And I've known for fifty years that she used to sing me something, and I have not been able to get at it. Not the tune, not one word of it, nothing. I could remember the fact of it the way you remember the fact of a town you've never been to."

She was looking at the door frame rather than at Maren.

"I've just had it back," she said. "All of it. Four verses. I know what her voice did on the third line."

The bell went, two notes, the second one flat.

Maren stood in the middle of the shop for some time with a blank brown book in her hands.

Then she climbed the ladder and put it back two thirds along, next to the one with the marbled boards, and went down, and got the seventh ledger out from under the counter, and opened it at the ninth page.

She looked at the last entry for a while. *29.viii.15 / I.V. / my sister's face / my sister's face.*

Then she took a pencil, and ruled four columns on the next blank line with a ruler because that was how it was done, and wrote:

16.x.26 / Ines H. / a song her mother sang /

And stopped at the fourth column, because she had absolutely no idea what went in it.

Four O'Clock

At four o'clock Maren went through the door that was a door.

The tea shop was two rooms and a counter and eleven tables, and at four o'clock in the middle of October there was one couple by the window in walking gear and nobody else. Tobias was doing something to a tray of scones with a cloth over it.

"You've come through," he said, without looking up. "That's the first time."

"Is there a rule about it?"

"There's a pot at four. There's been a pot at four for nineteen years, and for the last five weeks I've been drinking it on my own like a man in a Russian novel." He put the tray down. "Sit anywhere. Not that one, the leg's gone."

She sat, and he brought a brown pot and two cups and sat down opposite her, and for a minute neither of them said anything, which Maren found she did not mind.

Then she said, "I need to ask you something and I need you not to be kind about it."

"That's a hard promise to keep before I know what it is."

"Ines Hallow came in yesterday and asked me for a book off the top shelf."

Tobias picked up the pot and poured, steadily, two cups.

"Right," he said.

"You know about the shelf."

"I know there's a shelf and I know Ines has opinions about it and I know your aunt never once, in nineteen years, let me go up that ladder, and she let me rewire her back room." He put the pot down. "So. Go on."

Maren told him.

She told it badly, she thought afterwards, because she told it in order rather than in importance, the way she wrote documentation: the ladder, the blank spines, the blank pages, the ledger with its nine ruled pages, the four columns, *LENT*, Ines in the chair by the stove for twenty-three minutes, Ines coming out with her face wet saying *I know what her voice did on the third line*.

Tobias listened to all of it without interrupting once, which she appreciated more than she expected to, and turned his cup round twice on the saucer.

Before he answered he said something else entirely.

"Do you know what she talked about, at four o'clock?"

"No."

"Nor did I, for the first two years. I thought she came through for the tea." He was looking at the pot. "She came through to say things out loud. That was the whole function. She'd been on her own in that building since 1979 and she'd worked out that if you go three days without speaking a sentence longer than *two pounds fifty*, you start to go strange in a way you can't see from the inside. So she'd come through at four and say four or five things, out loud, to another person, and then she'd go back and open up again."

"What sort of things?"

"Whatever she'd been carrying about that day. A customer. The weather. Something she'd read." He hesitated. "You, sometimes."

Maren did not say anything.

"Not often, and never with any complaint in it, which I want you to know, because you're going to decide otherwise later on tonight." Tobias said it plainly, without softening it. "It was always the same shape. She'd say what you were doing, because you wrote to her and she'd read the letter that morning. And then she'd say, in exactly the same voice she used for the weather: *she'll come when she comes.* And then we'd talk about something else."

The couple by the window got up and started the business of coats.

"Right," said Tobias. "Now say the rest of it and I'll say the unkind thing you've asked me for."

"Right," he said again, when she had finished.

"Say the thing."

"I'm not going to say the thing."

"Say it anyway, or I'll say it for you and I'll say it worse."

He sat back.

"Ines Hallow is seventy-four," he said, "and she buried her husband in 2018 and she has been looking after your aunt in a quiet way for about six years, and last month the last person who remembered her as a young woman died. And she came into a room that smelled the way that room has smelled her whole life, and sat down in the chair her friend used to sit in, and held a book that her friend used to hand her, and she had a good cry and she remembered her mother singing."

"Yes."

"And that's a beautiful thing and it doesn't need a magic shelf."

"No," said Maren. "It doesn't."

"So."

"So that's what I thought at half past three yesterday afternoon, and I thought it very hard, because I would like it to be true and it's tidier and it means I can sell this building in November and go home." She had both hands round the cup. "And then I went and did what I actually do for a living, which is check things."

Tobias's eyebrows went up about a millimetre.

"There are two hundred and nine entries in that ledger," Maren said. "1961 to 2015. Names, most of them local, a lot of them families that are still here. Coll. Odell. Bril. Vane. Hallow. Third column is what the person got back, and it's always the same kind of thing: a smell, a tune, a taste, somebody's voice, one specific afternoon. Never an object. Never a fact. Never anything useful."

"That's a consistent delusion, not an inconsistent one. Sorry."

"I'm not finished." She put the cup down. "There's a fourth column. And the fourth column is the same kind of thing, and it has no name attached to it, and I couldn't work out what it was for two days."

"And now?"

"1974. H. Bril gets back the way his father laughed. Fourth column: *the second verse of anything*." Maren looked at him. "In 1981, Ines Hallow gets her mother's hand on the back of her neck. Fourth column: *the name of the cove past Skerry Point*."

Tobias had gone completely still.

"So this morning," said Maren, "I walked up to Ines Hallow's front door at half past eight, and I asked her one question, and I did not tell her why I was asking. I asked her what your aunt used to call the cove past Skerry Point."

The couple by the window laughed at something. Somewhere a fridge cut in.

"And Ines said," Maren went on, "that it was the strangest thing, because Ilse Vessel had known every name on that coast, every rock and every gutter and every bit of shingle, and there was one cove out past Skerry Point that she could never get hold of, all the years Ines knew her. She'd stop dead in the middle of a sentence. She used to laugh about it. She used to call it the one that got away."

Tobias put both palms flat on the table, quite slowly, and looked at them.

"That's not proof," he said.

"No."

"That's one name and an old woman's memory of a joke."

"Yes."

"And the odds of you fitting that to a column in a ledger, if you were already looking for it — "

"Are excellent," said Maren. "I know. I do this for a living. I know exactly how good I am at seeing a pattern I've decided to see."

She heard her own voice do something odd on the last word, and stopped, and started again.

"Here's the part I can't get round," she said. "The fourth column doesn't help. If she was writing a story for herself, why would she write down what it cost her? Nobody writes a fantasy where they lose. And if she was keeping a real record, why would she keep the second half at all, for forty-four years, in pencil, ruled with a ruler, when nobody was ever going to read it?"

Tobias did not answer for a while.

"You want me to tell you what to do," he said at last.

"No. God, no." Maren almost laughed. "I want you to know, because I've been in this town four days and you're the only person who has come through a wall to bring me bread, and I have discovered that I do not want to be the only one holding it."

Tobias Quay looked at her across the table for a moment with an expression she could not read at all.

Then he got up and went behind the counter and came back with a plate with two scones on it and put it down between them.

"Right," he said, sitting. "Then I'm holding it. I don't believe it, mind. I want that on the record."

"Noted."

"I'll believe it when I see it and possibly not then." He pushed the plate an inch towards her. "But I'm holding it. Eat something, you look like a coat on a hook."

A Small Grey Cat

The thing about the cat was that it took three days to arrive, and when it arrived it came in sideways.

Maren was in the back room on the Sunday afternoon, doing the job she had actually come to Saltmarch to do, which was to open every box in the building and decide what it was.

The back room held forty years of things that were not quite stock. Two crates of parish magazines. A box of Ordnance Survey maps from the seventies with the covers off. A biscuit tin of loose photographs, which she put aside for later and then, twenty minutes on, went and got again, because she had never in her life put something aside for later and meant it.

The photographs were mostly of the shop.

That was the first surprise. Ilse Vessel had owned a camera for sixty years and had used it almost exclusively to photograph her own premises: the window in snow, the window with a display of Christmas annuals, the interior with a new shelf in it, the interior with a different cat on the counter every fifteen years or so.

There were a few of people. Ines at about forty, laughing, with a cigarette. A man in a boat. A group outside the church who might have been anybody.

And near the bottom, a colour print gone slightly magenta with age, of a girl of about ten sitting cross-legged on the floor of the shop in the gap between the poetry and the local history, reading with her back against the shelf and her mouth open.

Maren looked at that one for a long time.

She had no memory of it being taken. She had a great many memories of sitting exactly there.

On the back, in pencil, in the small upright hand: *M., August, the summer of the endless one about the horses.*

She made tea and took the tin through to the shop and sat behind the counter with it, which she was aware was becoming a habit, and went through the rest of the photographs slowly.

And in among them, three from the bottom, there was one of the counter with a cat on it.

A small grey cat, sitting on the ledger, in the exact place where Maren had put her elbow four times that morning.

She looked at it and felt the ordinary warmth you feel, and turned it over, and there was nothing written on the back, and she turned it back and looked at the cat again and thought: *that was mine.*

Not hers, exactly. It had been the shop cat, and it had been there for six summers of her childhood, and it had slept on her feet in the small back room and had followed her along the harbour wall as far as the chandlery and no further, every single time, as though there were a line drawn there that only it could see.

The cat had been called something, and the something did not arrive.

Maren sat with the photograph in her hand and went at it again, patiently, the way you go at a jar lid.

She waited for it the way you wait for a name you have temporarily mislaid, which is to say with mild impatience and complete confidence, because that is how it always works: you stop pushing and it arrives from the side about four seconds later, usually while you are doing something else.

She put the photograph down and squared up a stack of paperbacks and made herself think about something else, deliberately, for a full minute.

Then she picked the photograph up again.

Nothing came.

She was not alarmed, at that point. She wanted to be clear about that afterwards, when she went back over it: at that point she was not alarmed at all. She was thirty-four and tired and had had four difficult days, and she had once, at university, entirely lost the word *escalator* for an afternoon.

So she did the sensible things.

She went through the alphabet, which is what everybody does and which has never once worked for anybody.

She tried to come at it sideways. She thought about the chandlery and the line the cat would not cross. She thought about the sound of the tin being tapped on the step at the back and the particular two-syllable call Ilse used to do, which she could hear perfectly, in Ilse's voice, out of the back door into the yard, and which had a shape to it, two syllables, second one falling.

She could hear the shape. There was nothing in it.

She thought: *I can hear my aunt calling a cat and I cannot hear what she is saying.*

That was when the back of her neck went cold.

She went and got the ledger.

There was no entry for the cat, of course, because the cat was not the point; the cat was the fourth column. She turned to the last ruled page and looked at the line she had written on Thursday afternoon in her own hand, which was nothing like her aunt's, and which now looked to her like the handwriting of a person who has signed something without reading it.

16.x.26 / Ines H. / a song her mother sang /

The fourth column empty. Because she had not known what went in it.

Maren sat on the stool behind the counter with her hands flat on the ledger and did the thing she was best at, which was to be extremely rigorous with herself at the worst possible moment.

One. She had been under considerable strain, had slept badly for four nights, and had spent two days deliberately marinating in the idea that the shelf took things from the lender. If she was going to invent a symptom, it would look precisely like this.

Two. She could not check it. That was the horror of the design, if it was a design. There was no way to test the loss of a thing whose absence is the only evidence for it. Anybody can fail to remember a cat's name. She could ring Ines and ask, and Ines would tell her, and she would then be a person who had been told a cat's name, which was not the same as a person who remembered it.

Three. And she was going to ring Ines, and she knew she was, and she also knew that she was going to wait until tomorrow, because tonight she wanted to sit with it.

She looked up at the top shelf, ten feet above the floor, forty blank spines in a row in the last of the daylight.

"Right," she said, out loud, in the empty shop.

She got a pencil.

She turned to the last ruled line, and in the fourth column, in her own bad handwriting, she wrote:

the name of the grey cat

And then, because she was a person who checked things and because if she was going to do this at all she was going to do it properly, she took a fresh sheet of paper and wrote at the top, in capitals, HELD, and underneath it she began to write down, as fast as she could and in no order at all, everything small she was certain she still had.

The two-syllable call, second syllable falling.

The smell of the shop in August with the door propped open.

The way her mother said *Maren* when she was pleased and the different way she said it when she was about to be reasonable.

Her father's telephone voice, which was two tones lower than his real one.

The taste of the fruit loaf Ines had left on the counter, which was on the plate in the back room and which she was, she realised, saving.

She filled a page and a half.

Then she stopped, and read it back, and found that the exercise had gone wrong in a way she had not anticipated.

It was not a list of things she had. It was a list of things she had *thought of*, which is a different set, and a much smaller one, and there was no method for getting from one to the other. She could write down her father's telephone voice because she had happened to remember that she had it. There was no procedure for writing down the ones she had not happened to remember.

Somewhere below the page and a half there was everything else: forty-two years of small sensory nothings, none of them itemised, none of them retrievable on demand, and the shelf could take any one of them tonight and she would find out about it in eleven years while looking at a photograph.

She sat with that for a while.

Then she did the only thing that was actually available, which was to add a line at the bottom in capitals: THIS LIST IS NOT THE INVENTORY. THE INVENTORY CANNOT BE MADE. And under that, smaller, because she was

too tired to be dignified about it: *She knew that. She wrote it down anyway. Do the same.*

Then she folded it in four and put it in the ledger at the ninth page, and turned the shop lights off, and went up.

The Notice on the Lamp Post

The notice went up on the Tuesday morning, on the lamp post outside the chandlery, in a plastic wallet, at a height that suited nobody.

Maren heard about it before she saw it, which was how everything worked in Saltmarch. Trine Bril came in at twenty past nine with the pushchair and did not take her coat off.

"You've seen it, then."

"Seen what?"

"Oh," said Trine, and then, "oh, no, I'm not doing this. Come and look at it yourself, I'm not standing in your shop being the one that tells you."

So Maren put the sign to CLOSED and walked up Quay Street in her cardigan with her arms folded, and there were four people already at the lamp post, and they moved aside for her in a way that told her everything before she had read a word.

PROPOSED SALT MARCH FERRY TERMINAL, said the notice. NOTICE OF INTENTION TO SEEK COMPULSORY PURCHASE POWERS.

Below it there was a map.

It was a good map, well drawn, in the flat blue and grey of council documents, and on it the harbour side of Quay Street was outlined in a red line, and inside the red line the individual buildings were shown as pale rectangles, and each rectangle had a number.

Number 2 was a rectangle like all the others.

Maren stood and read the whole of it, twice, in the cold, while people came and stood beside her and read over her shoulder and went away again.

Consultation closes 14 November. Written representations to the Head of Regeneration. Public meeting, Saltmarch church hall, 22 November, 7pm. Determination by full council, 30 November.

And then, in the smallest type on the sheet, in the part that people do not read:

Buildings within the designated area assessed as being of no special architectural or historic interest.

She went back and opened the shop, because it was twenty to ten and that was when it opened.

Then she stood behind the counter and shook, briefly, for about ninety seconds, with both hands flat on the wood, which she found extremely annoying, because she was not a person who shook and because she had, four days ago, been entirely prepared to sell this building to these people herself.

That was the part she could not get past. She had done the arithmetic on Wednesday with Tobias standing right there. She had run the whole thing to the end and found it reasonable.

And now there was a red line on a map, and inside the red line her aunt's shop was a pale rectangle of no special interest, and something in Maren Vessel had stood up out of its chair.

You don't get to have it both ways, she told herself. *You had four days. That's your entitlement. You had four days and you used them to decide it was worth about a hundred and forty thousand pounds.*

The bell went, two notes, second one flat.

Ines Hallow came in with the *Fenn Advertiser* folded under her arm, put it on the counter, and said, "Well?"

"It says the building is of no special architectural or historic interest."

"That's true, as it goes. It's a Victorian shop with a bad roof."

"I know it's true."

"So what's the matter with it?"

Maren opened her mouth to say something reasonable and heard herself say, instead:

"There's a photograph in a tin in the back room of me at ten years old sitting on that floor between the poetry and the local history, and it was taken by a woman who's dead, and it says on the back *the summer of the endless one about the

horses*, and I have no idea what book that was and now there is nobody alive to ask."

Ines Hallow looked at her for a second.

"Right," she said. "Good. I was worried you were going to be sensible about it."

They sat in the back room by the stove with the shop bell propped so they would hear it, and Ines went through the notice line by line with a pencil, in the manner of a woman who had done this before and enjoyed it.

"Consultation to the fourteenth. That's twenty-six days. Written representations, which means letters, which means they count them." She tapped the sheet. "Public meeting the twenty-second. That's the one that matters and it's the one they'd rather nobody came to, which is why it's a Sunday in November at seven o'clock."

"Does it ever work?"

"Sometimes it works." Ines did not look up. "In 1996 they were going to close the school and put the children on a bus to Fenn, and there were two hundred and eleven people in that hall, and it did not close for another nineteen years. So yes. Sometimes it works. Usually it doesn't, and I want to be honest with you, because you have had a bad week and I'm not going to add lying to it."

"What's the difference? Between the times it works and the times it doesn't."

"Numbers in the room," said Ines. "That's all it's ever been. Not the arguments. The arguments are the same every time and half of them are wrong. It's how many people take a Sunday evening in November and put a coat on."

Maren looked at the stove.

"There are four hundred and ten people in Saltmarch," she said. "I looked it up on the ferry."

"Four hundred and six. There's been a good year for the churchyard."

"And how many of them have been in this shop this year?"

Ines Hallow put the pencil down and looked at her, and for the first time since Thursday, since the chair and the twenty-three minutes and the wet face, there was something careful in it.

"Now," she said, "that is the question, isn't it."

The bell went out in the shop.

Maren got up. She was halfway to the doorway when Ines said, behind her, in a completely different voice:

"Did you write in the fourth column?"

Maren stopped with her hand on the frame.

"Yes."

"What did it cost you?"

"The name of a cat."

There was a pause.

"Ilse's grey one," said Ines. "The one that wouldn't go past the chandlery."

"Yes."

"She had that cat nineteen years." Ines was not looking at her. "You'll want me to tell you what it was called, and I'm not going to, and you'll be angry about that for a while."

"Why not?"

"Because if I tell you, you'll spend the next month checking whether it stuck, and you won't be able to, and it will make you mad." Ines folded the notice along its original crease. "There's the bell again. Go and mind your shop."

Maren went and minded her shop.

It was a man of about sixty in a fisherman's jumper, and he stood in the doorway with his cap in his hands and looked at the top shelf, ten feet up, and then at Maren.

"They're saying," he said, "in the tea shop. About Ines Hallow, and a book."

Maren said nothing.

"I'm not a fool," the man said. "I want that said first. I've come in here and I know how it sounds."

"What's your name?"

"Coll. Dinny Coll." He turned the cap over. "My wife died in March, and there was a thing she made with apricots, and I can't get at what it tasted like. I've tried. I've had the recipe out and I've made it myself twice and it isn't it."

The clock over the door, four minutes slow, went on being four minutes slow.

"Sit in the back," said Maren. "There's a chair by the stove."

She went up the ladder with him standing at the bottom holding his cap, which she wished he would not do, and put her hand flat along the row and went along it and stopped, this time, near the left-hand end, at a fat one with a broken hinge.

"Do I pay you?" he said, when she came down.

"No."

"Ise never took anything either. I asked my father once why not and he said it was because she'd have had to decide what it was worth." Dinny Coll turned the cap over. "How long does it take?"

"About twenty minutes, as far as I know. I've done this once and I wasn't in the room."

"Right."

He went through, and Maren shut the door, and then stood in her shop and did not sell anything to anybody for nineteen minutes, because nobody came in, because it was a Tuesday in October.

She stood at the counter with the ledger open at the ninth page and a pencil in her hand, and she wrote the first three columns and left the fourth alone.

20.x.26 / D. Coll / the taste of the thing his wife made with apricots /

Then she waited, and paid attention to herself, deliberately and systematically, the way you check a room for a smell. She went down the HELD list in her head, item by item. The two-syllable call. The shop in August. Her mother's two voices. Her father on the telephone.

They were all there. Everything was exactly where she had left it.

That was somehow worse than the alternative, because it meant she would not know until she stumbled on the gap, whenever that was, in a week or a year, in the middle of doing something else.

At twenty-four minutes Dinny Coll came out with the book held in both hands and his face rearranged.

"It had cardamom in it," he said. "That's what I couldn't get. Forty-one years and I never once asked her what was in it, because a man doesn't, and then she was gone in eleven weeks and I'd nothing to ask with." He put the book on the counter very carefully, the way you put down something that belongs to somebody else. "Cardamom, and too much lemon. She always put too much lemon in everything. I'd forgotten that as well and I've got it back for nothing."

"Not for nothing," said Maren.

Dinny Coll looked at her for a moment.

"No," he said. "I don't suppose so. Your aunt never said that part either." He put his cap on. "You'll want to know that I'll tell people. I'm not going to pretend I won't. I've a brother."

Dinny Coll's Brother

Dinny Coll's brother came in on the Wednesday morning at five past nine, before Maren had got the second light on.

He was older than Dinny and shorter and had the look of a man who had been sent. He stood inside the door with the cold coming in behind him and said, without any preliminary at all, "He says you did a thing for him."

"Sit down."

"I've not said what I want yet."

"You will, and you'll say it better sitting."

He sat on the stool by the local history, which nobody had ever sat on, and turned out to be called Robert, and to want the sound of his mother's front door, which had a particular catch in the latch that he had heard four thousand times and could no longer produce in his head, and which mattered to him for reasons he did not explain and Maren did not ask about.

He was in the back room for eighteen minutes.

When he came out he shook her hand, which nobody in Saltmarch had done yet, and left, and Maren wrote the third and fourth columns in the ledger and stood looking at what she had written.

21.x.26 / R. Coll / the catch in his mother's front door /

The fourth column blank again. Two loans in two days and she had no idea what either of them had cost.

She rang Ines at ten.

"I'm not telling you the cat's name."

"I know. That's not why I'm ringing." Maren had the phone jammed against her shoulder and the ledger open. "How did she keep track? Of the fourth column. How did she know what she'd lost, when the whole point is that you don't know you've lost it?"

There was a pause on the line long enough that Maren checked the screen.

"She had a system," said Ines at last. "I thought it was a bit mad, in 1990. I've come round to it."

"Tell me."

"Every Sunday night she wrote out a page. Just a page, whatever came, small things, the sort of thing nobody bothers to write down: the smell of the wash-house at her grandmother's, a bit of a song, the way a person said a word. And she dated it and she put it in the drawer and she never read it back."

"Never?"

"That was the rule she made and she kept it for twenty years. She said reading them back was the trap, because then you'd only be remembering the page." Ines's voice was very dry. "And then once a year, at the New Year, she'd take out the pages from five years before and read those, and go through them line by line, and anything on the list she could no longer get at, she'd know."

Maren sat down.

"That's not a system," she said. "That's an audit."

"That's what she called it. She used your word. She used to say *I've done the audit* and then she'd be short with me for about a fortnight." Down the line, a kettle started somewhere. "The last one she did was the January of 2015. She came round to mine on the second and sat where you sat on Tuesday, and she said, *Ines, I've lost eleven off the list and four of them are people.* And in the August she wrote her last line in that ledger and she stopped."

"Did she tell you why?"

"She told me what she'd lost. That's a different thing, and it's hers, and I'm not giving it to you over a telephone." A pause. "Come up on Sunday. Bring the ledger. I'll do you a dinner and I'll tell you the whole of it properly, at a table, the way it ought to be done."

"Sunday's the twenty-fifth."

"It is."

"That's three weeks before the consultation closes."

"It is," said Ines Hallow, "and I'll be doing a chicken, and you'll come."

Maren wrote the page that night.

She sat at the counter after closing with a sheet of A4 and the shop dark except for the light over the till, and found that it was much harder than it looked, because the instruction was to write down small things and everything that came to her arrived pre-sorted by importance, which was exactly the wrong sieve.

She got fourteen lines eventually. Some of them were embarrassing. The particular grey of the water off the east pier in March. The sound of her father folding a newspaper. A word her flatmate at university had used wrong for two years and which she had never corrected. The smell of the shop in August, which she had already written on the HELD list and which she wrote again because the rule said whatever comes.

She dated it and put it in the drawer under the till and did not read it back.

Then she got the HELD list out of the ledger, and looked at it, and after a while she tore it in half and put both halves in the bin.

It had been the wrong idea. Ilse's was better. The list of what you have is a list of what you have thought of; the page written weekly without reading back is a net that catches things while you are not looking, and in five years you find out what has gone through it.

She was aware, doing this, that she had just adopted a dead woman's practice without deciding to.

She was also aware that she had been in Saltmarch thirteen days, and that in her flat two hundred miles away there was a fridge with things in it, and a landlord who would want to know, and a job that she was doing badly on a laptop at a kitchen table at seven in the morning before the shop opened.

She had not told anybody she was staying.

She had not decided she was staying.

On the Thursday there were four of them.

That was the day it changed, and Maren could put her finger on the hour: half past eleven, when she looked up from pricing a box of Reader's Digest condensed and saw that there were four people in her shop and none of them was looking at a book.

They were standing about in the polite, elaborately casual way of people in a queue that nobody has admitted is a queue: one at the maps, one apparently reading

the notices in the window, one talking to Tobias, who had come through and was making it worse by being friendly.

She had, at that moment, a very clear view of two futures, and she looked at both of them properly, because it was the last morning on which looking would have been any use.

In the first one she said, pleasantly, that the shop was a shop, and that whatever people had heard in the tea shop had grown in the telling, and that there were some very good gardening books at two pounds fifty. It would take about a week for the story to die. Dinny Coll would be embarrassed and would get over it. Ines would be disappointed in a way she would never mention, which was the worst kind. And on the thirtieth of November a red line on a map would do what red lines do, and Maren would go back to a flat two hundred miles away having spent six weeks not becoming anybody.

In the second one she said the thing she said.

There was no version in which she looked at these four people and told them to come back later. That was the part she noticed, standing behind the counter with a pencil in her hand: that the decision had already been taken, some days ago, without her being consulted, and that what was happening now was merely the announcement.

Rule the first, she thought, and had no idea where the phrase had come from.

You will find out what you have decided by watching what you do.

Maren put the pencil down.

"Right," she said, loudly enough to carry. "Whoever's first."

There was a small terrible silence in which nobody wanted to be first, and then a woman of about fifty put her hand up like a child.

Maren took her through.

When she came out at twenty past twelve there were six people, and one of them was standing outside on the pavement in the rain because the shop was full, and Tobias had gone back through for chairs.

The Rules, Written on the Back of a Notice

By Saturday Maren had done eleven, and by Saturday night she had stopped.

She stopped because of a man called Skerrit who came in at four o'clock wanting the smell of a particular hospital corridor, and she had got halfway up the ladder before she heard what he had actually asked for and came back down.

"Why that?" she said.

"It's where I saw her last." He was perhaps sixty. He had come straight from the boat and had not changed. "Nineteen years ago and I can't get the room back at all, and if I could get the corridor I'd be nearer."

Maren stood with her hand on the ladder.

"I'm not doing that today," she said.

His face closed.

"I'm not saying no. I'm saying not today, and I'm going to tell you exactly why, and then you can decide whether you think I'm being high-handed, and you'd be within your rights." She came down and stood in front of him because it seemed like the sort of thing you did standing up. "I've done eleven of these in four days. I don't know what any of them cost, because the cost isn't mine to see until years later. And I've just noticed that I said yes to you before I'd heard the end of your sentence, and that's not care, that's momentum."

Skerrit looked at her.

"That's fair," he said, unexpectedly. "That's more than fair. My wife would have said the same and she'd have said it worse."

"Come Tuesday. Not because I'm making you queue. Because I want to have thought about it and you want me to have thought about it."

"Aye." He put his cap on. "Tuesday."

There had been another one, on the Friday, that she had not told anybody about and that was doing most of the work behind the decision.

A woman called Odell, seventy, granddaughter of the Mrs Odell in the second entry of 1961, had come in and asked for the smell of her own kitchen in the house she had grown up in, and Maren had gone up the ladder, and had been three rungs up when the woman said, from below, in a perfectly conversational voice:

"He'll be in it, though, won't he."

Maren had come back down.

It had taken twenty minutes at the stove to get the rest of it, and Maren had not asked one question, because the thing about not asking questions is that it is the only technique that works on somebody who has decided to tell you.

The father had not been a good man. That was the whole of what the woman said about him directly, and she said it once, and then talked about the kitchen for a quarter of an hour: the range, the wash-house door, a particular brown teapot, her mother at the table doing the football coupon.

"I want the room," she said at the end. "I've wanted the room for fifty years. I don't want him in it and I know he's in it. He was in it every day."

"Then I'm not going to be able to give you one without the other."

"No." The woman had put her cup down. "No, I didn't think you would. I'd got that far myself, on the way down."

They had sat there for a while.

"Can I come and sit in here sometimes anyway," the woman had said, "without the book," and Maren had said yes, and the woman had come in twice since and bought nothing and stayed forty minutes, and it was, Maren thought afterwards, the most useful thing the shop had done all week.

She shut at five, which was an hour early, and put the CLOSED sign round, and got the council notice off the counter where it had been sitting under a mug for a week.

Then she turned it over and wrote on the back of it, because there was no other paper to hand and because it seemed appropriate.

It took her an hour and a half and three attempts. What she ended up with was this:

RULES OF THE HIGH SHELF, worked out by M. Vessel in the fortnight after she inherited it, and written down because a practice that isn't written down is just a mood.

One. One a day. Not two. The queue can wait, the queue has waited eleven years already.

Two. Never on the same day as bad news, mine or theirs. A person who has just had a shock will ask for the wrong thing and get it.

Three. They say what they want out loud, in a full sentence, before I touch the ladder. If they can't finish the sentence they aren't ready.

Four. Never a child.

Five. Never for me.

Six. Write the third column at the time. Write the fourth column when you find out, however long that takes, even if it is years. Especially if it is years.

Seven. If I ever want to do one because I want something out of it, that is the day I stop.

She read them back.

Then she added, at the bottom, in smaller writing:

Eight. These are not her rules. Hers are lost. These are mine and they will be wrong somewhere and I will find out where.

She pinned the notice to the back of the door, council side inwards, and stood looking at it for a while with her arms folded.

The eleven had taught her one more thing that did not fit on a list, and she thought about it while she was pinning the notice up.

Nobody had asked for anything large.

That was the part she had not expected. She had braced, on the first morning, for people wanting the dead back: whole conversations, last words, a face across a table. Nothing of the sort had happened. Eleven people had come into a room with the chance to reach into their own past and take one thing out of it, and they had asked for a shed, a latch, a smell of apricots, a hymn tune, the exact green of a coat, the way a man cleared his throat before he read out loud.

She had assumed at first that they were being modest, and had been ready to tell them they could ask for more.

By about the sixth she had understood that they were not being modest at all. They were being accurate. The large things were not missing. Everybody knew what their mother's face looked like and how the funeral had gone and what had been said in the hospital corridor; those were carved into people so deeply that they showed on the outside.

What went were the small ones. The furniture of an ordinary afternoon. And nobody notices them going, and then one day there is a person you loved for forty years and you have their face and their voice and their opinions and you cannot get the sound of them coming up the path.

That's what it's for, Maren thought, with the drawing pin in her mouth. *It's not for grief. Grief looks after itself. It's for the wearing away, which nothing looks after.*

She put the pin in the corner of the notice and pushed it flat with her thumb.

Tobias came through at half five with two plates.

"You've shut early."

"I've shut early."

"That's the first time in a fortnight and I've come through to see whether you've had a nervous collapse." He put the plates down on the counter and looked at the door. "What's that?"

"Rules."

He read them. He read them all the way through, twice, which she was learning was how he read things, and stopped at four and at five for slightly longer than the others.

"Never a child," he said.

"Never a child."

"Why?"

"Because a child can't consent to a thing they can't understand, and because I don't know what happens if you give a person back something before they've finished losing it." Maren had thought about this one hardest. "Ines got a song back at seventy-four and it was a gift. If she'd got it back at nine it would just have been a song."

Tobias nodded slowly.

"And five," he said. "Never for you."

"That's the one that matters."

"Go on."

"Because the price falls on the lender." Maren leaned on the counter. "If I ever do one for myself, then I'm paying myself out of my own pocket, and there's no reason to stop. It becomes a thing I can do whenever I want a bit of my own past back, and I'll do it, because I am exactly the kind of person who would."

Tobias picked up his fork and did not eat with it.

"Can I say the unkind thing," he said, "or is it not that sort of evening?"

"You've earned it."

"Rule seven's already broken."

Maren went still.

"You're not doing this because eleven people in a fortnight wanted their mothers back," Tobias said. "Or you are, but that's not the whole of it. You're doing it because on the thirtieth of November there's a vote, and the one thing that might stop it is a room full of people who feel they owe this building something."

The gulls were going over towards the tip, the way they did at half past five.

"That's not why," said Maren.

"No?"

"No." She heard her own voice, and it was steady, and she was not at all sure it was honest. "But I thought of it. I thought of it on the Tuesday, standing right here, about four minutes after Dinny Coll went out of that door."

Tobias put the fork down.

"Right," he said. "Then eat your dinner, and put a nine on the list."

"There isn't a nine."

"There is now, and I'll give it you for nothing." He pushed the plate towards her. "*Nine. Say the ugly reason out loud to somebody once a week, whether or not it's still true.*"

The Crossroads at Tolm Head

The first one she noticed happened on the Sunday, on the way up to Ines Hallow's for the chicken.

Ines lived out past the school, up the hill road, in a bungalow with a wind-bent hedge and a view of the whole harbour, and the walk was twenty-five minutes and Maren had done it perhaps four hundred times between the ages of nine and fifteen.

She got as far as the crossroads at Tolm Head and stopped.

There were four roads. That was correct. There had always been four roads: the one she had come up, the one that went on over the top to the caravan site, the one down to the church, and the one that went right and along the contour towards the school and then the bungalows.

She stood in the middle of them with a bottle of wine in a bag and could not work out which was which.

Not could-not-remember in the ordinary way, where you dither for a second and then your feet start walking and turn out to be right. She looked at the right-hand road and it was a road. It was a perfectly good road with a hedge and a passing place and a gate. It had nothing attached to it at all.

She stood there for four minutes.

She knew it was four minutes because a car came past at the beginning and the same car came back at the end, which meant somebody had gone down to the church and turned round, and the second time it slowed and the window came down and it was Tobias Quay in a small green estate full of trays.

"You've been there a while," he said.

"I'm working out which road."

He looked at her.

"You've been coming up this hill since you were nine," he said.

"Yes."

"Maren."

"I know."

He pulled in properly and got out and came and stood beside her at the crossroads with the wind going through the hedge, and did not touch her, and did not say anything comforting, both of which she noticed.

"Right hand," he said. "Past the phone box that isn't there any more, third gate, that's Ines."

"Thank you."

"Do you want a lift?"

"No." She found that her voice had gone somewhere odd and brought it back. "No, I want to walk it. I want to walk it now and see if it takes."

It did not take.

She walked the right-hand road and it was familiar in every particular, hedge, passing place, gate, the concrete post with the reflector gone, the place where the tarmac changed colour because it had been dug up for something in about 2003. She recognised every yard of it.

The recognition arrived as she got to each thing and did not extend one step further. She could not, at any point, have said what came next.

Halfway along she stopped again, and this time it was deliberate, and she made herself do something she had been avoiding since Tolm Head.

She stood in the road and tried to walk the route in her head from the bottom.

Quay Street. The corner by the chandlery. Up past the school. And then the hill, and then

and then nothing. A flat grey absence with no edges to it, exactly the shape of the pause where the name of a cat should have been.

She tried it from the top instead, which she had read somewhere was a trick that worked. Ines's gate. The third gate. The concrete post with the reflector gone.

And then nothing again, from the other side.

The road existed in pieces. She was standing in one of them.

Maren discovered that she was not frightened, which surprised her, and that what she felt instead was something closer to the specific irritation of a professional whose tool has failed. She had spent twelve years being paid to hold a document in

her head and find the place where it contradicted itself. That was the whole job. That was the only thing she had ever been unambiguously good at.

You have been giving away the joins, she thought. *Not the facts. The order of the facts.*

She got to the bungalow at ten past one with the wine and stood outside the gate and did the arithmetic she had been avoiding for a hundred yards.

Eleven loans. Ines, the cat's name. Dinny Coll, unknown. Robert Coll, unknown. And then eight more in four days, one after another, and she had felt fine, and she had gone on feeling fine because the fourth column is invisible.

It isn't that you lose one thing per loan, she thought. *You don't know the exchange rate. You've never known the exchange rate. You just assumed it was one for one because that's what the ledger looks like.*

She rang the bell.

Ines took one look at her and said, "Sit down before you say anything," which turned out to be the correct order of operations.

The bungalow was too hot and smelled of chicken and there was a fire on that did not need to be on, and there were three framed photographs on the sideboard and one of them was of Ilse Vessel, outside the shop, squinting, in about 1990.

"She hated that one," said Ines, following her eye. "She said she looked like a magistrate. I keep it out because she hated it."

"Do you have many?"

"Four in fifty years. She wouldn't be photographed. She'd take them all day and she'd not be in one." Ines put a dish down. "It's the same thing, if you think about it. She spent sixty years recording the outside of her own life and none of the inside, and then she gave the inside away in instalments, and there is nobody now who can tell you what she was like at thirty. I can tell you what she was like at forty-five, and that's the earliest anybody living has got."

Maren sat down at the table.

"Is that what I'm doing?"

"I've no idea," said Ines. "You've been here a fortnight and you've already written a set of rules down and pinned them to a door, which she never did in her life, so on the available evidence, no." She sat. "Eat."

They ate for a while without talking, which Maren had not known was possible with somebody she had met three weeks ago.

"I'll tell you the thing I've never told her, though," Ines said, at about the halfway point. "The thing about that shelf is that it does not give anybody anything they need. Not once, in fifty years. It gives them something they *want*, which is a different article altogether."

"That's not nothing."

"No. It's not nothing at all, and I'd have paid a great deal of money for that song, and I want that understood before I say the next part." Ines put her fork down. "But there is not one person in this town whose life was changed by it. Not one. Old Coll got a smell of a shed. Robert got a door latch. I got four verses. We were all of us perfectly all right the day before and perfectly all right the day after, and we were happier for about a week."

"And the price was real."

"The price was always real," said Ines Hallow, "and it was always somebody else's, and that is the arrangement that I have been sitting inside of for forty-five years and have never once said out loud at a table."

The chicken was very good. Maren had not eaten a proper Sunday dinner in four years and had forgotten that they existed as a category, and she got about two thirds of the way through it before she put her knife down and said, "I've lost the hill road."

Ines went on eating for a moment.

"Which part."

"All of it. The order of it. I know every bit of it when I'm looking at the bit, and I can't get from one to the next in my head." Maren heard herself and stopped. "I stood at Tolm Head for four minutes."

"That's how it goes," said Ines. "It's never the whole thing. It's the joins."

"You knew."

"I knew what it did to her, which isn't the same as knowing what it'll do to you, and I've been waiting all week for you to arrive at the top of that hill and find out you couldn't." Ines put her cutlery down at last. "Eat the rest of that. I've a lemon thing after."

"Ines."

"Eat it, Maren, because in about twenty minutes I'm going to tell you a thing I promised her I'd never tell anybody, and I'd rather do it with the plates cleared and you with something inside you, because that is how it is done."

So Maren ate the rest of the chicken.

Afterwards, in the front room with the harbour going grey through the window and a lemon thing that turned out to be a kind of steamed pudding, Ines Hallow set a small tin box on the table between them and did not open it.

"Her sister was called Anneke," she said. "You won't have heard the name. There's a reason for that."

Anneke

"She was two years younger," said Ines, "and she went to Canada in the March of 1961 with a man from Fenn, and she never came back, and that is the entire outline of it. Everything else is detail."

Maren sat with the pudding going cold.

"1961," she said.

"You've noticed."

"That's when the ledger starts."

"The fourteenth of February, 1961," said Ines. "Anneke sailed on the third of March. So Ilse did the first one three weeks before her sister left, and I have wondered about that order for forty years and I have never been able to decide whether it means anything."

She turned the tin box round on the table without opening it.

"They wrote," she said. "Both of them, properly, every month, for fifty-four years. Anneke had four children and a hardware business in a place called Kenora and she sent photographs at Christmas and Ilse put every one of them in that tin. And Ilse never went. Not once. Anneke asked her every year for the first fifteen years and then stopped asking, and they went on writing every month, and there was no quarrel. I want that understood. There was no falling out. There was a boat sailing on the third of March and a shop that could not be shut, and then there were fifty-four years."

"She could have shut it for a fortnight."

"Yes," said Ines. "She could have."

She let that sit for a moment, which Maren understood to be deliberate.

"I asked her once, in about 1988," Ines said. "We'd had a drink, which we did perhaps twice a decade. And I said, Ilse, why have you never been. And she gave me an answer that took her about forty seconds and was entirely made of reasons, and every single reason was true, and I sat there and thought: that is a woman who has practised this."

"What were they?"

"The shop. The money, which was real, it was not a small thing to fly to Canada in 1970. Her mother, while her mother was alive. And after her mother died it was that Anneke had four children and no room, and after the children grew up it was that they were both too old for it, and by then it was 2001 and the answer had become true again, which is what happens if you keep an excuse long enough."

Ines turned the tin box a quarter turn.

"And then she said the real one, at the end, because we'd had a drink. She said: *if I went, I would have to find out whether we still knew each other, and while I don't go, we do.*"

Maren sat with that.

"That's the whole of it, then," she said.

"That's the whole of it, and I've had thirty-eight years to think about it, and I'll tell you the conclusion I've come to and you can do what you like with it." Ines looked up. "She was not a coward. People will tell you she was and they'll be wrong. She made one bad trade in 1961, out of fright, in a week when she was twenty-nine and her sister was going and there was nothing she could do about it. And then she spent fifty-four years being far too honest to pretend it had been anything else, and far too stubborn to fix it, and she paid for the whole arrangement monthly, in instalments, on the third of every month, at a writing desk, in that shop."

The tin box had photographs in it, and Ines went through them without particular ceremony, laying them out on the table in date order, which was how they were packed.

A girl of about twenty on a quay with a hat. The same woman at thirty with two children and a car. At forty, at fifty, thicker, greyer, in front of a shop with a sign in English that said COLES HARDWARE & FEED, laughing at whoever was holding the camera.

"She's got your aunt's face," said Maren.

"She has, and that's the whole of the thing, so hold on to it."

Ines put the last photograph down, which was of an old woman in a garden chair, taken from too far away, in the flat light of somebody's phone.

"That's the summer of 2014," she said. "One of the grandchildren sent it. And by then Ilse was eighty-seven and she'd been doing four or five of those loans a month for a decade, and she came to me in the January of 2015, after the audit, and she sat where you're sitting and she said, *Ines, I can't get Anneke's face.*"

The harbour outside had gone the colour of pewter.

"I said, well, there's a boxful," said Ines. "And she said, that's not it. She said: I can hold the photographs and I know that is my sister, and I cannot get her face in my head with nobody looking. She said, I've got her at twenty because of the one on the quay, and I've got her at fifty because of the one in front of the shop, and there is nothing behind them. She said: I have made a photograph album where a person used to be."

Maren did not say anything.

"So." Ines squared the photographs up into a stack, edge on the table, twice. "In the August, Anneke died. In her sleep, in Kenora, at eighty-five, and the telephone went at six in the morning and it was a grandson that Ilse had never met, being very kind, in a Canadian accent."

"And she used the shelf."

"On the twenty-ninth of August, 2015." Ines's voice did not change at all. "She wrote it in the ledger, and she went up the ladder, and she took one down, and she sat in that chair by the stove with it, for herself, which she had never done in fifty-four years."

"What happened?"

"She got it." Ines looked up, and her eyes were entirely dry, which made it worse. "She got her sister's face back. She told me that on the thirtieth, on the phone, and she was crying, and Ilse Vessel did not cry. She said it was like a door opening. She said, *I've got the whole of her, Ines, I've got her at thirty-eight in that kitchen.*"

"And the fourth column."

"You've read it."

"*My sister's face*," said Maren. "Both columns. The same words."

"By the Tuesday it had gone," said Ines. "All of it. Not just the bit she'd got back. The twenty and the fifty and the photographs on the quay, the lot, gone, in the way you can't feel from the inside until you go looking. She rang me on the Tuesday

evening and she said, in a completely ordinary voice, *I appear to have paid for it with itself.*"

The clock in the hall did whatever it did.

"And she never lent another book," said Ines Hallow, "and she never opened that tin again in eleven years, and she gave it to me in the July because she said she wanted it in a house where somebody could look at it and get something out of it."

Maren walked back down the hill road in the dark at half past six, and the whole way down she was doing the arithmetic and getting the same answer.

Rule five. *Never for me.*

She had written it on the back of a council notice on Saturday evening because it had seemed like the obvious structural weakness, the way you put a bolt on a door you can see somebody trying. She had thought she was being sensible.

She had, in fact, been reconstructing, from first principles and in about ninety minutes, a rule that a woman had paid for with her sister's face.

That was the part she could not get past, at the bottom of the hill, standing at the corner by the chandlery where a grey cat with no name had stopped every single time.

Every one of those rules on the back of the notice had been Ilse's first, probably by 1963. And she had never written them down, and she had never told anybody, and so they had died with her, and Maren was going to spend the next forty years discovering them one at a time in exactly the same order and at exactly the same price.

A practice that isn't written down is just a mood.

She let herself in and put the shop light on and got the seventh ledger out from under the counter, and turned past the nine ruled pages to the blank paper at the back.

Then she took the council notice off the door, and copied the nine rules into the ledger in ink, dated, and under them wrote:

These are not the whole of it. She had more and they are gone. When I find one, I will put it here, and I will put down what it cost me to find it, so that whoever gets this after me has to buy fewer of them.

Councillor Vane Looks at the Ceiling

Peder Vane came in on the last Wednesday of October, at twenty past two, in a good coat.

Maren knew who he was before he said anything, because she had spent the previous evening reading eleven years of council minutes on a laptop at the kitchen table, and because a man in a good coat in Saltmarch on a Wednesday afternoon is not a man who has come in about a book.

He did not introduce himself either. He came in, and the bell did its two notes, and he stood just inside the door and looked up.

Not at the shelves. At the ceiling.

"That's your flashing," he said.

"It is."

"It'll be the flashing round the stack, not the slates. They all do it along here, it's the pointing." He was still looking up. "Coll's nephew will tell you it's the slates because he can charge for slates."

"So I've been told."

Peder Vane brought his eyes down at last and looked at her, and there was nothing hostile in it, and Maren discovered that she had been braced for hostility and had no plan for its absence.

"Peder Vane," he said. "Regeneration and Harbour. I've come to say four things and then I'll go, and I'd rather say them here than at a meeting with forty people watching, because at a meeting I have to say them in the way you have to say things at meetings."

"Sit down, then."

"I'll stand, thank you."

"One," he said. "I'm sorry about Ilse. She spoke against me on the second of September for four minutes and she called me a man with a spreadsheet where his childhood ought to be, and it was the best thing anybody's said about me in nine years on that council, and I've written it down."

Maren, unwillingly, laughed.

"Two. The terminal is not a whim and it is not a developer's idea. The current pier gets a hundred and eighty days a year when the swell won't let the boat come alongside, and that number was ninety when I was a boy, and it will be two hundred and ten by 2040, and there is nobody in this room who can do anything about why."

"I've read the report."

"Then you'll know the rest of it. There's no doctor on the island past a nurse practitioner two days a week. There's no secondary school. If the boat can't run, a child at Fenn Academy sleeps in a hostel." He said all of this flatly, as a man reciting. "The terminal is a waiting room and a car deck and a berth that works in a force six. It is not glamorous and it will not make anybody rich and it is the only thing anybody has proposed in thirty years that keeps a family on this island."

"Three," said Maren.

"Three." For the first time something moved in his face. "I would rather it were not this street. I have said so in committee eleven times and it is in the minutes and it made no difference, because the harbour side of Quay Street is the only ground with the depth behind it, and I can either have the terminal there or not have it. There is no third place. I have looked. I have personally walked this harbour with an engineer in the rain and there is no third place."

He stopped.

"And four?" said Maren.

"Four is the one I came for." He put both hands in his coat pockets. "There is going to be a meeting on the twenty-second in the church hall, and Ines Hallow is going to fill it, because Ines Hallow has filled that hall twice in my lifetime and she is better at it than I am. And I want you to know, before that happens, that I am not going to say anything about you at that meeting, and that if anybody else does I will stop them."

"Say anything about me."

"You've been here a fortnight and there are people queueing on my street on a Tuesday morning." Peder Vane's voice was very level. "I'm not asking what for. I don't want to know. If I knew I would have to have an opinion, and my opinion would be no use to anybody, and there is a version of this where somebody stands up in that hall on the twenty-second and calls you something, and it would be a very effective thing to do to the other side of the argument, and I am telling you now that I will not do it and I will not let it be done."

The shop was extremely quiet.

"Why not?" said Maren.

Peder Vane looked at the ceiling again for a moment, at the brown bloom the size of a dinner plate.

"Because my mother came in here in about 1974," he said, "and my father came in here in the March of 1990 and was told no, and he came home and he told me about it, which he would not have done if he had been ashamed of it. And I have known that this shop does something for forty years, and I have never once been in it, and I have put a red line round it, and those three facts are all true at the same time and I have to carry them about."

"Can I ask you something," said Maren, "that you're allowed not to answer."

"You can ask."

"If the meeting on the twenty-second goes badly for you. If Ines fills that hall and the report has to be rewritten and the vote slips to the spring." She watched him. "What happens to you?"

Peder Vane considered this for slightly longer than she expected.

"Nothing happens to me," he said. "That's the part people always get wrong. I'm not going to lose an election over a ferry terminal, there isn't an election worth losing. I'll go on being a man who does eleven meetings a month in a room above a library in Fenn."

"Then why do you care?"

"Because I've got two years left of being able to be bothered," said Peder Vane, "and there is one thing on this island that I actually understand, and it is the swell in the outer harbour, and if I do not get this built before I stop being able to be bothered, nobody else is going to, because nobody else has read the report."

He said it entirely without self-pity, which made it land harder.

"My son's in Aberdeen," he said. "He's twenty-six. He went at eighteen and he did not go because there was no work, there is work, there is more work here than

there are people. He went because when he was fifteen he did his standard grades at Fenn Academy and he slept in a hostel from the Monday to the Friday for two years, because the boat could not be relied on, and by the end of it he had a life over there and we were the people he came back to at weekends."

He stopped.

"That's not an argument," he said. "I'm aware that it isn't an argument. It's the reason, though, and you asked me for the reason, and I'd rather you had the real one than the one that fits on a leaflet."

He turned to go.

"Mr Vane."

He stopped with his hand on the door.

"Your father asked for something in 1990," said Maren. "The ledger says he was refused. It doesn't say what he asked for."

"No," said Peder Vane. "It wouldn't."

"Do you know?"

"I know exactly," he said, "and I'm not going to tell you, because you'd hand it to me, and I've watched you for two minutes and I'm fairly sure you'd hand it to me on the spot and be pleased about it, and then neither of us would ever be able to say afterwards that the vote was clean."

The bell went, two notes, the second one flat.

Maren stood in the middle of her shop for some time.

Then she went and wrote, on the blank paper at the back of the seventh ledger, under the nine rules:

Ten. If a man who can decide something asks, the answer is no until the thing is decided. Found 29.x.26. Cost: nothing yet, and I do not trust that.

The Fourteenth of November

The consultation closed at five o'clock on the fourteenth of November, and by the twelfth Ines Hallow had sixty-one letters.

She had them in a lever arch file, in plastic wallets, indexed, and she brought the file into the shop on the Wednesday and put it on the counter with the air of a woman producing evidence.

"Sixty-one," said Maren.

"Sixty-one, and eleven more promised, and I'll have those by Friday because I'll go and get them." Ines opened the file. "Now. They count letters, but they weigh them, and I want you to understand the difference, because it's the whole game."

"Weigh them how?"

"A letter that says *we love our bookshop* goes on the pile and is worth nothing, because the officer writing the report can summarise forty of those in one line and he will." Ines turned wallets. "A letter that says *I am a district nurse and on the eleventh of March I could not get to a patient at Braer because the boat did not run and I want the council to know what that was like* goes in the report by name, because he cannot summarise it without lying."

"That's an argument for the terminal."

"It is," said Ines, without blinking. "That's the one Vane will use and it's the good one and I'd use it myself. What we've got is a different one and it's narrower and I want you to hear it before you decide whether you can live with it."

She took out a single sheet.

"There is nothing in the report about what is on this street now," she said. "Not one line. It says *retail units, low footfall, no special interest*. That is the whole description of your shop and Tobias Quay's tea shop and Skerrit's yard. So the case

is not *don't build the terminal*, because we will lose that and we should lose it. The case is *you have described this street wrongly, and here are sixty-one people describing it correctly, and you must now put the real description in the report and vote on that.*"

Maren read the sheet.

"That won't stop it."

"It stops it about one time in four," said Ines Hallow. "Which is one time in four more than shouting."

Maren wrote hers that night, and it took four drafts, and the first three were all the same mistake in different words.

The first was about Ilse, and she got two paragraphs in before she saw what she was doing, which was asking a planning committee to be moved by a dead woman they had never met. The second was about the building, and it was worse, because the building was a Victorian shop with a bad roof and she had said so herself. The third was angry, and she read it back at midnight and recognised the voice in it, which was the voice of a person who has been in a town for a month and has decided she is from there.

The fourth one she wrote in twenty minutes, standing up, and it was one page.

It said that she had inherited the shop at 2 Quay Street on the fourteenth of September and had come to Saltmarch intending to sell it, and that she was writing partly to correct the record and partly to disclose an interest. It said that the report described the premises as *retail units, low footfall*. It said that between the twelfth of October and the twelfth of November she had recorded four hundred and eleven separate visits to the shop, of which fewer than seventy had involved a purchase.

It said that she was aware this was an argument against the shop as a business and she was making it anyway, because it was the truth and because the report had counted the wrong thing.

It said, at the end: *I do not ask the council to abandon the terminal. I ask it to write down what is actually on this street before it votes to remove it, so that whatever is decided is decided about the real place.*

She read it back once, put it in an envelope, and walked it up to the post box at half past eleven at night in the rain, because if she left it until morning she would improve it.

Cato Bril was in the shop for the whole of that conversation, on the floor in the gap between the poetry and the local history, with her back against the shelf, reading.

She had been in the shop for some part of most days for a month. Maren had a system for it now: the comics went out on a low shelf near the window, and there was a beanbag that Tobias had produced from somewhere, and there were rules about crisps that had been negotiated in good faith on both sides.

Trine came for her at half past four, most days. On the days Trine was on the late shift at Fenn, Cato stayed until six and did her homework at the counter and Maren checked her French, badly.

Aaron Bril had died in the February of two years before, at thirty-nine, of the thing that takes men of thirty-nine with no warning at all, in the middle of a Tuesday, at work. Maren had this from Tobias in nine words and had not asked for more.

Nobody had told Maren that Cato had stopped talking for four months afterwards. She worked it out herself, eventually, from the way Trine watched her daughter talk.

On the evening of the twelfth, Maren went through to the tea shop at ten past six to give Tobias back a tray, and was gone perhaps four minutes.

She came back through and the shop was empty and the door was on the latch, which was correct, because Cato let herself out when Trine texted, and had done for a fortnight, and had never once failed to pull the door to.

Maren locked up and did the till and went upstairs.

It was not until the following morning, at twenty past nine, doing the thing she now did every morning without thinking about it, that she went up the ladder to check the row.

She counted twice.

Then she came down and stood at the counter and put both hands flat on it and made herself go through it properly, in order, without panicking, because panicking would take about four minutes that she did not have.

Thirty-nine books. There had been forty. She had counted them on the first night with a torch in her teeth and she had counted them again on the Sunday after Ines told her about Anneke, because after Anneke she had counted everything.

The gap was at the left-hand end, three in from the wall.

She went back up and looked at the gap, and at the dust on the shelf, and there was a clean rectangle where a book had been, and a smear at the front edge of it about the width of a hand.

A small hand.

She did not go to the Brils' that morning.

She sat at the counter and made herself think about it for an hour and a half, and did not open the shop, and afterwards she was glad of that hour and a half, because everything she thought of first was wrong.

Her first instinct was to go straight up there and get it back, and that was wrong, because a twelve-year-old who has taken something and been chased for it becomes a twelve-year-old who hides it.

Her second was to ring Trine, and that was wrong for a reason it took her forty minutes to articulate: because whatever Cato had asked for, she had asked for it in a room by herself, on purpose, without telling her mother, and there was going to be a reason for that, and Maren was not going to be the person who handed it to Trine before Cato had.

Her third instinct, which arrived at about eleven o'clock and which she recognised with a certain amount of self-disgust, was that this was interesting. That the rule had been *never a child*, and now she was going to find out why, at somebody else's expense, without having had to break it herself.

She wrote that one down in the ledger too, because it seemed important to have a record of it.

Eleven. The rule you did not break can still be broken, and you will notice, on that day, a small part of you that is glad to be finding out. Found 13.xi.26.

Then she put her coat on and walked up to the Brils' and knocked, and Cato Bril opened the door with her thumb in a book she was not reading, and looked at Maren, and did not say anything at all.

"I'm not cross," said Maren.

"You are."

"I'm frightened," said Maren, "which looks the same from outside, and I'd rather tell you the true one."

What Cato Took

They sat on the wall at the bottom of the Brils' garden, which was not comfortable and was not overlooked, and which Cato chose.

"How did you know it was me?"

"Because there's a handprint in the dust and it's the size of your hand, and because you're the only person who's been in that shop on their own for a month." Maren had her hands in her sleeves against the cold. "Where is it?"

"Under my bed."

"All right."

Cato looked sideways at her, plainly waiting for the rest.

"That's it," said Maren. "That's the whole of the questions about the book. I'd like it back and I'd like it back today, and we'll get to that. The thing I actually want to ask is what you got."

There was a long silence. Down at the harbour somebody was running an engine.

"His voice," said Cato.

Maren kept absolutely still.

"I could do it for about a year," said Cato, to the garden. "After. I could do him saying things. And then one day I did him saying *right then* and it came out wrong and it's been wrong ever since, and I've done it about a thousand times and it gets wronger every time you do it, that's the thing nobody tells you. It's like a photocopy of a photocopy."

"Yes."

"And Mum's got videos on her phone but you can't watch them because then she cries for two days, so." Cato shrugged, an enormous shrug, the shrug of somebody holding something up. "So I took a book."

"What did you ask for?"

"Him saying *right then*." She said it very fast. "That's all. I didn't ask for a whole thing. I just wanted the two words, because if I've got the two words right I can build the rest off it, like tuning."

Maren put her hand over her mouth for a second, which she regretted, because Cato saw it.

"It worked," said Cato. "It's exactly right. I've got it. It's not even like remembering, it's like he's — " She stopped, and started again, more carefully, because she was twelve and precise and she had been thinking about this for a day and a half. "I've got the actual sound. And I've been doing it about every ten minutes since Wednesday night."

"Every ten minutes."

"Yeah."

"Cato." Maren turned to look at her properly. "Is it still right?"

And Cato Bril, who had opened the door with her thumb in a book she was not reading, put her face in her hands and said, through them, "I don't know. I don't know any more. That's why I've been doing it, I keep checking whether it's still right and I can't tell, and every time I check it might be the check that wrecks it."

Maren did not say anything for a while, because there was nothing available that was both true and comforting and she was not going to pick one.

"Right," she said eventually. "I'm going to tell you three things, and one of them is going to make you angry."

"Go on, then."

"One. You did not steal that book. You borrowed it out of a lending shelf without asking, which is a rubbish thing to do and it's not stealing, and I'm not going to let you carry it about as if it were."

Cato's shoulders came down about an inch.

"Two. The thing you're doing, the checking, is the thing that will wreck it, and I can't prove that and I'm fairly sure of it anyway. My aunt had a rule about not reading things back for exactly that reason and she kept it for twenty years."

"So what am I supposed to do, never think about him?"

"No. You're supposed to stop *testing* him." Maren looked at the harbour. "There's a difference between remembering somebody and taking the memory out to check it's still there. One of them is living with a person. The other is an inventory, and inventories wear things out."

Cato took her hands down.

"That's the two," she said. "What's the one that makes me angry?"

"Three." Maren made herself say it plainly. "It cost something. Everything off that shelf costs something. And it didn't cost you, and I need you to understand that before you decide how you feel about it, because you're going to want to have paid and you didn't."

"Who paid?"

"I did."

"That's not — " Cato stopped. Her face went through several things at speed. "That's not fair. I didn't ask you. I didn't even ask you, that's the whole point, I took it so I wouldn't have to ask anybody, so how can it — "

"It doesn't care who asked," said Maren. "That's the design. The book comes off my shelf and the bill comes to me, and that is true whether I hand it to you or whether you climb up and get it while I'm next door with a tray."

"Then what did it take?"

"I don't know yet."

"When will you know?"

"Sometimes days," said Maren. "Sometimes years. That's the other part of the design."

"There's a fourth thing," said Cato.

"Go on."

"You said three."

"I did. You've found a fourth. What is it?"

Cato swung her heels against the wall twice.

"How did you know about the checking," she said. "Because I've not told anyone that. I've not even told anyone I do it. And you said it like you already knew."

Maren thought about lying, briefly, in the way you consider a route and reject it.

"Because I did the same thing," she said. "Not with a voice. With a photograph."

"Of who?"

"Of nobody. Of a cat." She heard how it sounded. "That's not the point. The point is that when my aunt died I found a photograph of a shop cat I'd known when I was your age, and I couldn't remember what it was called, and for about four days I took that photograph out roughly every hour and looked at it and waited."

"Did it come?"

"No. And here's the thing I want you to have, because it took me a fortnight and it cost me something to work out." Maren turned to face her properly. "By about the third day I wasn't looking at the cat any more. I was looking at the photograph. I'd learned the photograph. I knew where the mug was on the counter and which way the light went and there was a bit of the ledger showing at the bottom edge, and every single one of those things had pushed something else out."

Cato had gone very still.

"So the checking doesn't just risk wrecking it," said Maren. "It replaces it. You end up with a beautiful clear memory of the thing you've been checking with."

"That's horrible."

"It is."

"So what do you do instead?" Cato's voice had gone up. "That's what nobody ever says. Everyone says don't dwell on it, don't pick at it, and nobody ever says what you're supposed to do with the hours."

"You let it come to you when it comes." Maren said it slowly, because she was working it out as she said it. "You don't go and get it. And in between you do something with your hands, and you go to school, and you're rude to me about my French accent, and one Tuesday in March you'll be doing something completely unrelated and he'll say *right then* in your head without being asked, and that one is real, and it'll be worth more than four hundred of the other kind."

Cato Bril looked at the harbour for a long moment.

"That's a rubbish answer," she said.

"It's the true one."

"I know." She wiped her face with the back of her wrist, once, businesslike. "It's still rubbish."

Cato went and got the book, and brought it down, and did not hand it over immediately.

"Can I ask you something rude?"

"You can ask me anything at all today."

"Are you going to stop doing it?" Cato held the book against her chest with both arms, which Maren had seen an old woman do in a doorway a month before. "Because everybody in the town's talking about it, and my mum said she might go, and if you stop because of me then that's a thing I did to everybody, and I'd rather know now."

Maren took a long time over that one.

"I don't know," she said. "That's the honest answer and I'm not going to give you a nicer one. But I'll tell you what I do know, which is that if I stop, it will not be because of you. It'll be because of me. And if anybody in this town ever says different, you send them to me."

Cato Bril handed over the book.

"It's got nothing in it," she said. "Did you know? I looked. It's just blank paper the whole way through, and I sat there with it for twenty minutes like an idiot and then it happened anyway."

"I know."

"That's mental."

"It is," Maren agreed, and stood up off the cold wall. "Come down tomorrow. Bring your French, it was a disgrace."

The Way She Said It

It arrived on the Sunday, eleven days later, in the middle of doing something else.

That was how Ines had said it would go and Maren had not properly believed her, because you cannot believe a thing like that in advance; you can only agree that it is probably true and go on living as though it is not.

She was on the telephone to her mother.

They spoke every three weeks or so, and had done for eleven years, and the calls ran about twenty minutes and were pleasant and slightly effortful on both sides and covered the same ground: her mother's knee, the neighbours, whether Maren was eating, a book her mother was reading. Since October there had been a new topic, which was the shop, and her mother approached it the way you approach a dog you have not been introduced to.

"And is it warm enough? In the flat?"

"It's warm if you light the stove by four."

"Your aunt was never warm enough in that building. I said so in about 1990 and she looked at me." A pause. "Are you staying, Maren?"

"I don't know."

"Well." Her mother let it go, which she had been doing for a month, and which Maren had begun to understand was costing her something. "Well. You'll say when you say."

And then, at the end, winding up, in the ordinary way, her mother said her name. She said, "All right, Maren, I'll let you go."

And Maren stood in the back room with the phone against her ear and the kettle going and heard, quite clearly, that it was wrong.

It was not wrong in any way she could have described to another person.

The voice was her mother's voice. The word was her name. The sentence was one she had heard four hundred times in eleven years of three-weekly telephone calls, in exactly that position, at exactly that point in the winding up.

There had been two ways her mother said *Maren*.

She knew that. She had written it on the HELD list on the second Sunday, before she tore the HELD list up: *the way her mother said Maren when she was pleased and the different way when she was about to be reasonable.* She had written it down because it was one of the small certain things, and she had been slightly pleased with herself for noticing it, the way you are.

And now there was a voice saying her name on a telephone, and it was one of the two, and she could not tell which, and she could not get at the other one to compare.

She could not get at either of them.

She had, she discovered, standing perfectly still with a kettle boiling four feet away, a fact about her mother's voice and nothing underneath it at all. *There were two ways she said it.* She could no more produce them than she could produce the name of a grey cat.

"Maren? Have I lost you?"

"No," said Maren. "No, you're there. Mum, I'll ring you Wednesday."

"That's not three weeks."

"No," said Maren. "It isn't."

She sat on the floor of the back room with her back against the stove, which was too hot, for about ten minutes.

Then she got up and got the ledger and wrote it in the fourth column, on the line she had opened on the twelfth of November and left half finished, and she was surprised to find that her hand was steady.

12.xi.26 / C. Bril (not lent, taken) / two words in her father's voice / the two ways my mother said my name

She looked at that for a long time.

The arithmetic was not complicated and there was no comfort anywhere in it. A twelve-year-old had climbed a ladder while Maren was next door with a tray, and had asked for two words, and had got them, and the bill had come to a woman two

hundred yards away, and had been paid out of the one thing on the whole list that Maren would have chosen last.

It doesn't care who asked.

She had said that on a cold wall on Friday, in the voice of a person explaining a system she understood. She had not, at the time, understood anything at all.

Before he came she did one more thing, and it was the worst hour of the month.

She got the drawer open under the till and took out the five Sunday pages she had written since the nineteenth of October, and she broke Ilse's rule and read them.

She had known she was going to do it from about the moment she put the phone down. She had told herself she would not, and had made tea, and had stood in the back room, and had then gone and done it, and the interesting thing was how little resistance there had been in the end.

Five pages. Sixty-odd lines, in her own handwriting, in five different moods.

She read them the way she read a document at work, which was the only way she had, and she went down the list one line at a time and asked, of each one: *can I get at this.*

Fifty-one of them, yes. Immediately and completely, the way you can.

Four of them, no.

The grey of the water off the east pier in March, which she had written on the very first page and which she could now produce only as the phrase *grey, in March*. The sound of her father folding a newspaper, which was gone entirely and which she had not thought about since she wrote it down. A particular corner of the school playing field where the ground dipped. And her mother's two voices, which she had known about since one o'clock that afternoon.

Five loans a week for a month. Four gone off a list of sixty.

She got a pencil and worked it out on the back of an envelope, properly, because if she was going to know a thing she was going to know the size of it.

If the list was representative, and there was no reason to think it was, she had lost something in the order of six or seven per cent of everything small she had, in five weeks.

She looked at that number for a while.

Then she wrote, in the ledger, under rule eleven:

Twelve. Do not read the pages back. She said so and I did it anyway, on the day I most wanted to, which is the day the rule is for. Found 23.xi.26. Cost: I now know the rate, and knowing the rate is not free.

Tobias came through at half six with soup and found her sitting behind the counter with the shop lights off and the ledger open, and he took one look and put the bowl down and did not ask.

"Sit," she said.

He sat on the stool by the local history that nobody sat on.

"It's the way my mother says my name," said Maren.

Tobias closed his eyes briefly.

"And she's alive," he said.

"She's alive, she's sixty-eight, she's got a bad knee, she rings me every three weeks and I've just told her I'll ring her Wednesday." Maren heard her own voice arrive at something and let it. "That's the part I can't hold. Ilse lost her sister's face and her sister was dead. Ines lost a cove she'd not walked to in fifty years. I've lost something that is **still happening**. She's going to say my name on Wednesday and she's going to say it one of the two ways, and I'm going to hear it, and it will mean nothing, and she will never know."

Tobias did not say anything for a while.

"Are you going to tell her?"

"How?" Maren almost laughed. "Mum, I've mislaid the way you say my name. Mum, I've been running a lending library out of the top shelf and the invoice came to me."

"Then that's your answer about Wednesday."

"It is." She shut the ledger. "I'm going to ring her on Wednesday and I'm going to talk about her knee."

The harbour did its evening noise through the window.

"I've thought of the ugly reason," Maren said. "It's Sunday, so I owe you it."

"Go on."

"The ugly reason is that I'm sitting here and part of me is doing sums about the meeting on the twenty-second." She said it flatly, looking at the counter. "Sixty-one letters. Eleven days. And a small, extremely practical voice in my head has spent the last hour pointing out that if I do four a day between now and then, I will have put something in the hands of about forty households, and forty households is a hall."

Tobias Quay did not tell her that she would not do it.

"And?" he said.

"And I don't know," said Maren. "That's why I said it out loud."

The Shelf Is Closed

She shut it on the Thursday morning, the twentieth of November, which was two days before the meeting in the church hall and ten days before the vote.

She did it before opening, at twenty past eight, in the dark, on her own, because she had worked out at about four in the morning that if she waited until there were people in the shop she would not do it.

There was no ceremony available. She went up the ladder and counted, which was now a thing she did the way other people check a gas ring, and then she came down and got the roll of brown paper and the tape from under the counter and went back up and taped a single strip of paper along the front edge of the shelf, from the wall to the far end, about four inches high.

It did not hide the books. It was not meant to. You could see the blank spines over the top of it perfectly well from the floor.

On the paper, in marker, in capitals, she wrote:

THIS SHELF IS CLOSED.
NOT FOR A WHILE. FOR GOOD.
ASK ME AND I WILL TELL YOU WHY.

Then she came down and put the ladder back and opened at twenty to nine.

Nobody said anything for two hours, which was worse than shouting.

They came in, and they looked up, because everybody looked up now on the way in, and they read it, and then they got very interested in the gardening or the maps and they left within about four minutes.

At eleven Skeritt came in, the man with the hospital corridor, who had been coming in on Tuesdays for three weeks and had never once asked again, because

Maren had told him to come Tuesday and he had made a private arrangement with himself about that.

He read the paper. He stood underneath it with his cap in his hands.

"Right," he said.

"Ask me."

"I don't need to ask you." He turned round. "You'll not do mine, then."

"No."

"Because of the girl."

Maren had been braced for this since Friday and had decided to answer it every time it was asked, in full, however many times that turned out to be.

"No," she said. "Cato's how I found out. It's not why."

"Then why?"

"Because I've done twenty-six of these in six weeks and I can now measure what it's cost me, and the number is roughly seven per cent." She said it steadily. "That's seven per cent of everything small I've got, gone, in six weeks. Not the big things. The small ones, which is all there is once you get past about five of the big ones. At that rate I have got somewhere between four and seven years of being a person who can remember an ordinary afternoon."

Skerrit did not say anything.

"And I want to be very clear about the next part," said Maren, "because it's the part I'd get wrong if I were you and I'd want somebody to say it out loud. I am not doing this because I've decided it's wrong to give things to people. I've been giving things to people for six weeks and it has been the best six weeks I've had in about a decade and I would like to go on doing it."

"But."

"But I worked out on Saturday that I have started to think of my own memory as a fund." She looked at the shelf. "And once you think of a thing as a fund, you spend it. There's no version where you don't. You just get better at telling yourself which withdrawals are the good ones."

Skerrit put his cap on and took it off again.

"You'll get people saying you had yours and now you've shut it," he said.

"I know."

"I'm not saying it. I'm telling you it'll get said."

"It'll be true, as well," said Maren. "That's the annoying part. I did get mine. I got six weeks of being the woman who could do the thing, and I got a shop full of

people, and I got asked to a dinner and I got told about Anneke. Nobody in this town got anything as good as I got."

Skerrit stood there for a moment.

"My wife," he said, "would have liked you enormously, and would have said you talk too much."

"She'd have been right."

"She generally was." He went to the door and stopped. "You'll have the letter from me anyway. For the meeting. That's not conditional and I'd not want you thinking it was."

There were nineteen more that day, and Maren answered every one of them, and by four o'clock she had learned that the same explanation gets shorter each time you give it and that this is not a good thing.

Trine Bril came at half twelve and was the only person who cried, and did it briskly, and apologised for it twice, and said the thing that Maren had been most afraid of and least able to prepare for, which was: "It's not for me. I never asked. It's that I'd started thinking Cato would have it when she was grown."

Maren had no answer to that at all, and said so.

Old Mrs Odell came at two minutes past three, the woman from the kitchen with the father in it, and did not mention the shelf, and bought a book about herbaceous borders for two pounds fifty which she did not want, and stayed forty minutes.

And a man Maren had never seen, off the boat, said, "That's a shame," and then, unexpectedly, "my mother used to come in here in the sixties," and told her about it for ten minutes, and did not ask for anything, and went.

By half four she had worked out the shape of it, and it was not what she had braced for.

Nobody was angry. That was the thing. She had spent two nights preparing for anger and had got, instead, about nineteen instances of a much harder emotion, which was a sort of embarrassed disappointment on somebody else's behalf: the face people make when a thing they had privately been counting on turns out not to have been promised to them.

They'd built a plan round it, she wrote in the ledger that night, before Ines came in. *In five weeks. Nobody said so, including to themselves, and now they've

all had to take it apart in a shop in front of the woman who did it, which is the worst possible place, and they have all been perfectly decent about it.*

Ines Hallow came at two and did not look up at the shelf at all, which meant she had heard before she came.

She sat in the chair by the stove without being asked and took her gloves off finger by finger, which Maren had learned meant that something was going to be said.

"You've done it in the wrong order," Ines said.

"I know."

"Do you." Ines put the gloves in her lap. "Say it, then, and I'll know whether you do."

"I've shut it two days before the meeting," said Maren, "which means I've thrown away the one thing that would have filled that hall, in the week it would have worked. Ines, you have sixty-one letters. If I'd gone on doing four a day until Saturday you'd have had a hundred and forty and they'd all have been warm."

"That's the one."

"I thought about waiting until the first of December."

"Of course you did."

"For about an hour and a half on Sunday night, and I got as far as working out that nobody would ever know, because nobody but me can see the fourth column." Maren was standing behind the counter with both hands flat on it. "And then I noticed what I was doing, which was working out the latest possible date at which I could stop and still call it stopping."

Ines Hallow looked at her for a long moment.

"Else would have waited," she said.

That landed in a way Maren had not been ready for.

"Would she?"

"She waited fifty-four years to get on a boat." Ines picked her gloves back up. "I loved that woman for half a century and I buried her in September and I will tell you the truth about her until the day I die, and the truth is that she was extremely good at finding the honest reason to do the thing she was going to do anyway. I've watched you for six weeks and I think you're worse at it than she was."

"Is that a compliment?"

"It's the best one I've got," said Ines Hallow.

The Church Hall, Twenty-Second of November

The church hall held a hundred and forty seated and Ines had put out ninety chairs, which Maren thought was pessimistic until she saw the room at ten to seven and thought it was wildly optimistic.

There were eleven people in it. Three of them were putting out the chairs.

"It's ten to," said Ines, who was doing the urn.

"There are eleven people."

"There are eleven people at ten to seven, which is when there are eleven people." Ines did not look round. "Nobody in this town has ever gone to anything at ten to. Go and sit down and stop counting, you're doing it out loud."

Maren went and sat down in the third row and counted silently instead, which was worse.

At five to seven there were twenty-six. At seven there were sixty, and the noise level had changed, and Tobias arrived with four boxes of something and had to go round the outside.

At ten past seven, when the chairman finally stood up because he could not reasonably wait any longer, there were about a hundred and ninety people in a hall with ninety chairs, and they were standing three deep along the back wall, and somebody had propped the fire doors open and there was a row of them out in the porch in coats.

Maren sat in the third row with her hands in her lap and did not trust herself to look round.

It was not a good meeting, if you judged meetings by their arguments.

Half of what was said was wrong. A man near the front spoke for four minutes about a right of way that had been extinguished in 1974. A woman explained at length that the council could not compulsorily purchase a freehold, which it could. Somebody raised the sewage.

Peder Vane took all of it. He stood at the front with his hands behind his back and answered every single one straight, including the wrong ones, including the rude ones, and he did not once say *as I have already explained*, and Maren, who had come prepared to dislike him more than she did, found that by twenty to eight she was watching a man do a difficult job properly.

He put the case. He put it better than the report did. He said the numbers about the swell and the numbers about the school and he said the thing about the hostel, and he did not use his son, which Maren noticed and thought about for a long time afterwards.

Then Ines Hallow stood up.

She had, as far as Maren could tell, no notes at all.

"I've three things," she said, "and then I'll sit down, and I'd like Mr Vane to know before I start that I'm not going to say anything he can disagree with, which is deliberate and will annoy him."

There was a laugh, and Vane inclined his head about an inch.

"One. Nobody in this hall is against the terminal. I want that in the minutes because it will not be in the report. We have all been on that boat and we have all stood on that pier in a force six and we would all like our children to be able to sit an exam without sleeping in Fenn." She let that sit. "So there is no argument here tonight about whether. The argument is about what the council writes down before it votes."

She held up a single sheet of paper.

"Two. This is the description of Quay Street in the officer's report, in full. It is eleven words long. *Retail units, low footfall, no special architectural or historic interest.*"

The hall was quiet.

"Three," said Ines Hallow. "I have sixty-one letters and I'll be handing them in, and I'm not going to read them out because that is a way of making people cry and it is beneath everybody. I'll read one line from one, which the writer has given me permission for, and it's from a woman of thirty-one who works at the fish plant."

She put her glasses on.

"*It's the only room in Saltmarch you can go into without buying something and without anybody asking you what's wrong.*"

She took her glasses off.

"That is not in the eleven words," she said. "It cannot be in the eleven words. And you may still knock it down, and you may be right to knock it down, but I am asking this council to write down what it is knocking down first, because we are going to have to live here afterwards and so are you."

She sat down.

Nobody clapped, because Saltmarch did not clap at meetings, and the silence went on about three seconds too long to be comfortable and was, Maren understood afterwards, the loudest thing that happened all evening.

Before that there were seven others, and Maren watched the room learn something over the course of about twenty minutes, which she had not expected and which she thought about for a long time afterwards.

The first three who stood up did what people do at meetings, which is to argue. They argued about the sewage and the right of way and the valuation, and Vane answered them, and they sat down having lost, because they were wrong and he had the report.

The fourth was a woman of about sixty who ran the post office counter in the Spar, and she did not argue at all.

She said: "I'd like to say what happens on a Thursday."

And then she described a Thursday. Twelve minutes of it, in complete detail, without a point: the fish van at half nine, the two men who sit on the bench by the chandlery in all weathers, who comes in for a paper and when, which of them can't manage the step, the woman who comes down from the caravan site every fortnight and buys nothing and talks to her for a quarter of an hour, and what the street sounds like at four when the school comes out.

Nobody interrupted her. The chairman, who had been cutting people off at three minutes, did not cut her off.

When she sat down there was that same slightly-too-long silence, and then a man stood up and said, "I'd like to say what happens on a Sunday," and did.

After him there was a girl of about nineteen who worked at the fish plant and who described the walk from the pier to her mother's house, and a retired teacher

who described what he could see from his front window, and Skerrit, who stood up and said one sentence, which was, "I have been in the tea shop at four o'clock every day for eleven years and I would like that in the minutes," and sat down.

Maren, in the third row, watched an officer of the council at the side table stop writing at about the fourth of these, and then start again, faster, and then turn his page over.

Nobody had organised it. She was certain of that, then and afterwards, and she asked Ines directly on the Monday and Ines said, with what appeared to be genuine surprise, "Organised it? I'd not have dared. If I'd asked six people to stand up and describe a Thursday I'd have got six speeches about the harbour board."

Then the chairman said, "Is there anybody else," and a hundred and ninety people found something to look at, and Maren felt herself getting up before she had decided to.

She had not prepared anything. That was the honest position and she led with it.

"My name's Maren Vessel and I've been in this town six weeks and I'm the wrong person to be standing up." She heard her own voice go out into the hall and it sounded like somebody else's. "I want to say one thing, and it isn't about the shop, and then I'll sit down."

She looked at the sheet of paper in Ines's hand rather than at the room.

"I came here in October to sell that building. I want that on the record, because a lot of people in this room have been very kind to me and some of them think I came back for the town, and I didn't. I came with a folder from a solicitor and I read the probate valuation twice on the train."

Somewhere at the back, somebody shifted.

"I'd have sold it to the council in November and gone home and I'd have thought I was being sensible, and the reason I'd have thought that is that the only description of the place I had was the one in the report." Maren made herself look up. "*Retail units, low footfall.* That was my description too. I'm not standing here as a person who always knew better. I'm standing here as somebody who had exactly the same eleven words in her head six weeks ago and got them off me because I stood in the room for a month."

She stopped, and found there was one more sentence.

"You can't hand that to a committee. That's the problem, and I don't have an answer to it. All I can tell you is that the eleven words are what you get when

nobody has stood in the room, and that everybody in this hall who has stood in it is here tonight, and there are a hundred and ninety of us, and that has to be worth something as a fact even if it isn't an argument."

She sat down.

Her hands were shaking, which annoyed her.

Tobias Quay, three seats along, did not look at her, and passed a paper bag down the row without turning his head, and inside it was a scone, and she ate it in a church hall in the middle of a planning meeting and did not care at all.

What Tobias Said in the Yard

The row happened on the Monday, in the yard, over a bin.

That was the shape of it from outside, and Maren was aware even at the time that anybody watching would have thought they were arguing about a bin, and that this is how it generally goes.

The bin was the tea shop's, and it had been in Maren's half of the yard for nineteen years by arrangement with Ilse, and Tobias had moved it that morning without saying anything because the new arrangement for the recycling started in December and he had been meaning to sort it out for a fortnight.

Maren came out at half nine and found the yard rearranged and said, "You could have asked."

And Tobias, who had been up since four and had had the meeting and the weekend and a supplier who had let him down, said, "It's a bin, Maren," in a voice that was not the voice he used.

That would have been the end of it, and it was not, because Maren said:

"It's my yard."

There was a small silence in which both of them heard it.

"Right," said Tobias.

"That's not what I meant."

"No, it is, though." He was not angry. He was worse than angry: he had gone reasonable. "It's exactly what you meant and it's true. It's your yard, and it's your building, and on the thirtieth you'll find out what it's worth, and I'll find out what mine's worth, and then you'll go back to your flat and I'll go and work for somebody in Fenn."

"That's not fair."

"No," he agreed, "it isn't, and I'd like to take it back, and I'm not going to, because I've been not saying it for four weeks and it's making me stupid."

He put the bin down.

"You've not told anybody whether you're staying," he said.

"I don't know whether I'm staying."

"You've been here six weeks. You've got a lending register in ink and a set of rules pinned to a door and a twelve-year-old doing her French at your counter, and you stood up in a hall on Saturday in front of a hundred and ninety people, and you have not once, to anybody, including Ines, including me, said the words *I am staying*." He picked up the lid and put it on. "And I'd like to say that this is because you're careful, which you are. But I've watched you make about nine large decisions in six weeks and take all of them in an afternoon."

Maren stood with her arms folded in the cold.

"Say the rest of it."

"The rest of it is that I think you're waiting for the vote." Tobias looked at her properly. "I think that if it goes against, you'll go home and be sad about it for a year and it will not have been your fault. And if it goes for, you'll stay, and that will not have been your decision either. Either way somebody else will have taken it, and you can spend the whole of the rest of your life saying that a council did this to you."

"That's an ugly thing to say."

"It's Monday," said Tobias. "It's owed."

She went back inside and stood behind the counter and was furious for about forty minutes, which was the useful part, and then stopped being furious, which was worse.

Because the thing about a man who has gone reasonable at you in a yard is that his sentences stay in the room afterwards and you cannot argue with them, and Maren had a shop to run and a Tuesday to get through and nothing to do all afternoon except sell four books and turn *either way somebody else will have taken it* over and over like a coin.

She had, she admitted at about two o'clock, taken nine large decisions in six weeks.

She had decided to open the shop, on the second morning, by turning a sign round without noticing. She had decided to lend to Ines. She had decided to go on

lending, in front of four people, in about eleven seconds. She had written the rules on a Saturday evening in ninety minutes. She had shut the shelf in the dark on her own before opening. She had written a letter to a council at half past eleven at night and posted it in the rain specifically so she could not improve it in the morning.

Every one of those had taken an afternoon at the outside, and most of them had taken less, and none of them had been careful, and she had been right about all of them so far as she could tell.

And the one decision that was actually hers, the only one nobody else was waiting on, the one that cost nothing and inconvenienced no one and required her simply to say a sentence to another person, had been sitting untouched for six weeks.

I am staying.

She said it out loud in the empty shop at ten past two, to see what it did, and it did nothing at all, and that was somehow the most annoying part of the entire day.

She did not speak to him for two days, which in a building with a shared chimney breast and a door that was a door was an achievement requiring real commitment from both parties.

On the Wednesday she went through at four o'clock and sat down at the table by the window without being invited, and Tobias brought the pot and two cups and sat down opposite, and neither of them said anything for about ninety seconds.

"You were right about the vote," said Maren.

"I'd have preferred to be wrong."

"You were right about the vote and you were wrong about the reason, and I've had two days to work out the difference, so I'm going to say it badly." She turned her cup round. "I'm not waiting for the council to decide whether I stay. I'm waiting for the council to decide whether staying counts."

Tobias frowned.

"Go on."

"If they vote it down and I stay, then I'm a woman who stayed to run a bookshop in a town she left at twenty-three." Maren was looking at the table. "And if they vote it through and I stay anyway, in a building that's coming down in eighteen months, with no shop at the end of it, then I'm just a person who lives here. And I have never once in my life been just a person who lives somewhere. I've always had the job. The job's been the whole of it since I was twenty-two."

"That's what you're frightened of."

"That's what I'm frightened of, and it's pathetic, and I'd have said it on Monday in the yard if you'd asked me the right question." She looked up. "You asked me whether I was staying. Nobody's asked me the other one."

"Which is?"

"Whether I like it here." Maren heard her own voice do something and let it. "Nobody has asked me that. Not once in six weeks. Everybody has asked me what I'm going to do with the building."

Tobias Quay put both hands round his cup.

"Do you like it here?" he said.

And Maren Vessel, who had lost the hill road and the name of a cat and the two ways her mother said her name, and who had a set of rules pinned to a door and a lending register in ink, sat in a tea shop at four o'clock in the afternoon in the last week of November and discovered that she had to think about it for a considerably shorter time than she had expected.

"Yes," she said.

"Right," said Tobias.

"That's all you're going to say?"

"That's all I'm going to say today, because there's a vote on Saturday and I'm not having the rest of it decided in the same week as a planning determination." He poured, steadily, two cups. "Ask me again in December."

"That's very restrained of you."

"I'm forty," said Tobias Quay, "and I've a business that's about to be compulsorily purchased, and I have learned to take things in the correct order. Eat something."

What Peder Vane's Father Asked For

He came on the Thursday, four days before the vote, at half past four in the dark, and he did not have the good coat on.

"You've shut it," he said, looking up at the brown paper.

"A fortnight ago."

"I know. I'd heard." He stood in the middle of the shop with his hands at his sides. "That's why I've come. I could not have come while it was open. I hope you can see that."

"Sit down, Mr Vane."

"Peder."

"Sit down, Peder."

He sat on the stool by the local history, which had had more use in six weeks than in the previous decade, and he looked at his hands for a while.

"My father asked for a Sunday afternoon in 1990," he said. "The fourth of March. He asked for the whole of it, start to finish, and your aunt told him no."

Maren waited.

"It was the Sunday before my mother went into hospital in Fenn for the operation she did not come out of." Peder Vane said it without any particular weight, the way you say a thing you have said in your own head five thousand times. "She was fifty-one. We had lunch, the three of us, and it was an entirely ordinary lunch and nobody said anything of any consequence at all, and that is the point of it, that is exactly the point of it."

"He wanted the ordinary lunch."

"He wanted the four hours." Vane looked up. "He'd got the hospital. He'd got the last week and the funeral and all of it in tremendous detail, he had those until the day he died, they never faded at all. What he'd lost by 1990 was the Sunday. He could tell you it happened. He could not get inside it."

The stove ticked.

"And Ilse said no," said Maren.

"Ilse said no, and he came home and he told me about it at the kitchen table, and I was sixteen, and I remember exactly what he said." Peder Vane's voice did not change. "He said: *she told me I'd be trading a room I can't get into for a room I'm still living in, and I've thought about it walking home and she's right, and I'm angry about it and she's right.*"

Maren sat down on the chair behind the counter.

"She told him what it cost."

"She told him what it cost *him*. Not what it cost her." He shook his head slowly. "I didn't understand that part until about three weeks ago, and I've had a long time to think about this, and I want to say that I think it does her a great deal of credit. She could have said *no, because it costs me too much*, and he'd have accepted it and gone home feeling he'd asked something greedy. She said no in a way that let him keep his dignity, and she took the whole of the price of that on herself, and she did it in about four sentences at a counter in about 1990."

"Can I ask you something about him," said Maren.

"You can."

"Did he ever get it? Later. On his own." She was thinking of a girl on a cold wall in November. "People do. It comes when you're doing something else."

Peder Vane thought about it honestly, which she had come to expect from him and which still surprised her every time.

"Bits," he said. "He told me once, in about 2004, that he'd got the tablecloth. He was very pleased about it. He rang me in Aberdeen on a Wednesday to tell me he'd remembered a tablecloth."

"And the rest?"

"No." He shook his head. "And I'll tell you what I've worked out about that, because I've had nineteen years. He wasn't after the afternoon. He knew what happened in it. He could have written you a list."

"Then what?"

"He wanted to be in a room with her again where nothing was wrong." Vane looked at the floor. "That's what he'd lost. Not the facts. The state of not knowing yet. And there's no getting that back, is there, because the whole thing that made it worth having was that neither of them knew what was coming, and he knew what was coming from about the following Thursday onwards for the rest of his life."

The shop was quiet for a while.

"So it wouldn't have worked," said Maren.

"That's the thing I cannot decide." Peder Vane's voice was perfectly level. "I've gone round it for nineteen years. Either your aunt understood that better than he did and said no for exactly that reason, in which case she did him a considerable kindness and he never knew it. Or she just didn't want to pay, and dressed it up, and he walked home admiring her for it."

"Which do you think?"

"I think the first one," he said, "on the balance of what I know about her, which is not very much. And I think that if I'd been sixteen and known it was a choice at all, I'd have wanted somebody to ask me."

"So," said Maren, after a while. "Ask me."

"I'm not going to ask you."

"You've come here four days before a vote and told me a story about your father. Ask me."

Peder Vane looked at the brown paper strip along the shelf.

"No," he said. "And I'll tell you why, and then you'll have to believe me or not, and I've no way of proving it."

"Go on."

"Because I've come here to tell you how I'm voting on Saturday, and I could not have told you that if I'd also asked you for something." He put his hands on his knees. "I'm voting for it. I've never not been going to. The report goes to committee with the description rewritten, which is what Ines asked for and which I supported and which passed on Tuesday, and it will not make one particle of difference to the outcome, and I told her that on Tuesday afternoon and she said she knew."

Maren did not say anything.

"There'll be nine votes," said Vane. "Four are mine. Three are against, and always have been, for reasons that have nothing to do with your street. Two of them will decide on the night, and one of those two was at your meeting."

"And you're telling me this because?"

"Because you'd have heard it on Sunday anyway, and because I'd rather you heard it from me in a shop than from the *Fenn Advertiser*." He stood up. "And because there is a version of this where I let you find out on Sunday, having spent four days hoping I'd changed my mind, and I have been that man in other people's stories and I've not enjoyed it."

He got to the door and stopped, as he had the first time.

"Can I say the other thing," he said, "or would you rather I went."

"Say it."

"If I had come in here in October, when it was open." Peder Vane was not looking at her. "I'd have asked. That's the whole of what I want to say. I've spent six weeks telling myself I wouldn't have, and I've had the argument with myself on the harbour road at least a dozen times, and about ten days ago I lost it. I would have come in and I would have asked for that Sunday afternoon, because I was there too, and I've lost it as well, and I am fifty-two and I have been carrying a hole where a lunch was for thirty-five years."

The bell over the door was very loud in the quiet.

"You shut it before I could," he said. "I don't know whether you'll understand this. I've been grateful about it for a fortnight and I've not been able to say so to anybody."

He went, and Maren sat in the dark shop for some time.

Then she got the ledger and wrote, on the blank paper at the back, under rule twelve:

Thirteen. There is no version of this where the person who is refused does not deserve it. Every single one of them deserves it. That is not a reason to say yes and it is the reason it is hard, and if it ever stops being hard, stop. Found 27.xi.26. Cost: nothing. It was already paid, in about 1990, by a woman at this counter.

The Thirtieth of November

The determination was taken at four minutes past nine on the Saturday evening in a committee room above the library in Fenn, and Maren was not there.

She had intended to go. Ines had offered a lift and there was a public gallery with eleven seats in it, and Maren had got as far as putting a coat on at half past five and had then taken it off again and rung Ines and said she was not coming, and Ines had said "Good" and put the phone down, which was the closest thing to approval available in that part of the world.

So she spent the evening in the shop instead, with the lights on and the sign at CLOSED, doing the thing she had been putting off since October, which was the boxes in the back room.

There were nine left. She did four.

Two of them were stock and one was parish magazines and the fourth was full of Ilse's mother's things, wrapped in newspaper from 1961, and Maren sat on the floor and unwrapped a whole dinner service that nobody had eaten off in sixty-five years and put it all back exactly as she had found it.

Tobias came through at half seven with a plate and went away again without saying anything, which she thought was the single most tactful thing anybody had ever done for her.

At twenty past nine her phone went. It was Ines, and it was a text, and it was four words.

Six to three. Through.

Maren put the phone face down on the counter.

She had been ready for this. She had been ready for it since Thursday and she had spent the intervening two days arranging herself into somebody who would take it well, and she discovered, sitting on the floor of the back room with a 1961 newspaper in her hands, that all of that preparation had been done by a completely different woman and was of no use to her whatsoever.

She cried for about four minutes, which she had not done since the fourteenth of September and had not done properly since a long time before that.

Then she got up and washed her face at the little sink and put the kettle on and stood in the middle of the shop and looked at it.

Eighteen months. That was the timetable in the report, and the report was now the decision: notice to treat in the spring, vacant possession by the summer of 2028, demolition in the autumn.

Eighteen months of Tuesdays.

She stood there and did the arithmetic she had been doing since October, and it came out differently, and she stood very still while it did.

You can be a person who lives somewhere.

Tobias came through at twenty to ten, which meant he had been sitting on his own side of the wall for twenty minutes deciding whether to.

He did not say he was sorry, which was correct, because he was not sorry about the vote in any way that would have been useful to say out loud, and because his own shop was in the same red line and he had not mentioned that once all evening.

He sat down on the floor of the back room with his back against the boxes, which put him below her eye level, and Maren understood that this was deliberate and had been thought about.

"Ines has texted you," he said.

"Six to three."

"She texted me as well. Four words each, no punctuation. She'll have done nineteen of them from a car park." He put his head back against the boxes. "How long have we got?"

"Vacant possession summer 2028."

"Eighteen months." He worked at that for a moment. "That's four hundred and fifty Tuesdays."

"That's not how you count Tuesdays."

"It's how I count them tonight." He looked at the ceiling, at the brown bloom the size of a dinner plate. "You'll want to get that flashing done."

Maren looked at him.

"It's coming down in eighteen months," she said.

"Aye."

"Tobias, they're going to demolish it."

"They are." He did not move. "And there's a hole in your roof for eighteen months of weather, and there'll be a bucket in that corner every time it comes from the north east, and you'll be moving stock about with a torch in your teeth in February. Six hundred quid, Dinny Coll, he'll do it in a day."

Maren opened her mouth and shut it again.

"That's the daftest thing anybody's ever said to me," she said.

"No it isn't."

"Six hundred pounds on a building with a demolition order."

"Six hundred pounds on eighteen months of not having a bucket in the corner." Tobias got up off the floor, slowly, the way large men do. "It's not an investment. Nobody's getting it back. It's just that you're going to be in here every day until June 2028 and there's no reason for it to be miserable."

He picked up the plate he had brought in at half seven and which she had not touched.

"That's the whole of my philosophy," he said, "and it's taken me forty years and it fits on a postcard. Ring Dinny in the morning."

Ines rang at ten.

"You'll have had my text."

"I have."

"Right." A pause, and the sound of a kettle at the other end too, because it was that sort of evening in that sort of place. "Two things and then I'll let you go to bed. One: the description got rewritten. It's in the minutes. Eleven words became a page and a half and it names the shop and it names Quay's and it quotes the woman from the fish plant. That is on a public record now and it will be there in fifty years."

"It didn't work."

"It didn't stop it. It worked." Ines's voice was perfectly steady. "In 1996 we did not stop the school closing either. We put nineteen years on it. Nobody hands you the nineteen years at the time, Maren, you find out afterwards."

Maren sat down on the stool by the local history.

"What's two?"

"Two is that a hundred and ninety people put a coat on for you on a Saturday in November," said Ines Hallow, "and there are four hundred and six of us, and I have lived here my whole life and I have never seen that hall like that. Not for the school. Not for anything."

"That wasn't for me."

"No," Ines agreed. "It was for the room. Which you have been standing in for six weeks pretending to be a shopkeeper, and which will be gone in a year and a half, and which is not the same thing as the building."

There was a long silence on the line.

"Ines."

"Mm."

"How do you keep a room without the building?"

"I've absolutely no idea," said Ines Hallow, "and I'm seventy-four and I'll be dead before it's answered properly, and if you find out any part of it I would be very grateful if you'd tell me while I'm still here to enjoy it. Go to bed."

Maren did not go to bed.

She sat at the counter until half eleven with the seventh ledger open in front of her, and she went through the nine ruled pages one more time, two hundred and thirty-six entries now, forty-four years of Ilse's and six weeks of her own.

Then she turned to the blank paper at the back, past the thirteen rules, and started a new page, and wrote at the top of it, in capitals, because she had discovered over six weeks that she thought better with a ruler in her hand:

THINGS THAT ARE NOT THE BUILDING

The chair by the stove.

Four o'clock.

Somewhere a person can stand for twenty minutes without buying anything.

The rules, which are written down, which is the entire difference between a practice and a mood.

Cato's French, which is a disgrace.

The fact that Ines Hallow will tell anybody the truth about a woman she loved for fifty years, on request, at a table, with a chicken.

She looked at the list.

Then she added one more line, and it was the one she had been circling for six weeks and had not been able to write down anywhere, and it went in the ledger because the ledger was where true things went in this building.

The shelf, which I have shut, and which is not on this list, and which I notice I did not put on it, and which I am going to have to think about for a considerable time.

The Letter in the Wrong Ledger

She found it on the ninth of December, in the fourth ledger, which was 1978 to 1986 and which she had no reason to open.

She opened it because she had decided to catalogue the whole stock properly before the spring, which was an absurd thing to do to a building scheduled for demolition and which she had started anyway on the second of December, and because the fourth ledger had a gap in the numbering she wanted to understand.

There was an envelope between pages ninety and ninety-one.

It was addressed to her, in the small upright hand, and it said *Maren* and nothing else, and it had never been posted and never been sealed.

She stood at the counter and looked at it for about a minute and a half before she opened it, and afterwards she could not remember what she had thought about in that minute and a half.

4th September 2015

Maren,

You rang on Tuesday and asked to come and work here and I said no, and I did it badly, and I have written this four times.

I said no because the shop does not make enough money for two, which is true and is not the reason.

The reason is that I am eighty-eight and I have been doing a thing in this building for fifty-four years and I have recently found out what it has cost me, and I have not decided yet whether I am going to tell you about it. If I let you come here at twenty-three you will find out in a fortnight, because you are not stupid and you notice things, and then it will be yours whether either of us likes it or not.

I have watched three people inherit that shelf in my lifetime. My mother had it, and my aunt Grete had it before her. Nobody was ever told. Everybody found out, and by the time you have found out you have already done one, and by the time you have done one you have already decided, and that is not a choice, it is a landslide with a person standing in it.

So I have said no to you, on the telephone, for a false reason, and you were very polite about it and I could hear that you were hurt, and I am sorry.

Here is what I intend. I intend to shut the shelf, which I ought to have done in 1990 and did not, and then in a year or two when there is nothing left in this building but books and a bad roof I will ring you and ask you to come, and you will be twenty-five and you will have a proper start.

If you are reading this then I did not do that, for one reason or another, and I would like to say something to you about it and I find I cannot, so I will say this instead.

The shelf is not the shop. I have got those two things confused for fifty-four years and it has cost me my sister's face and it will, I think, cost me the rest of it before I have done. Do not make my arrangement. You may make a worse one of your own if you like, that is your right, but do not make mine.

Whatever you do, write it down. I never wrote any of it down. There is nobody I can ask.

I am going to put this in the fourth ledger where I will not have to look at it.

Ilse

Maren read it three times and then sat on the floor between the poetry and the local history with her back against the shelf, in the gap where a girl of about ten had sat in a photograph in a biscuit tin, and stayed there for a long while.

It was the fourth of September.

Ten days before she died. Six days before the last stock entry, *Bril boy, comics, no charge.* Two months after she had given a tin of photographs to Ines Hallow because she wanted it in a house where somebody could look at it.

She had been putting things where they would be found.

Maren had told the eleven years to three people in her life, and the version she had told was always the same and had taken about a minute, and it went: *I asked to

go and work in the shop when I finished, and she said no, and we never talked about it again, and after that it was easier not to go.*

She had believed that version completely. She had been believing it for eleven years, and it was accurate in every particular, and it was also, she now understood, a description of the outside of the building.

She had not been refused. She had been protected, badly, by a woman with eleven months to live who was too proud and too frightened and too *stubborn for her own* to say why, and who had written it down four times and posted it nowhere and put it in a ledger nobody opens.

I have not decided yet whether I am going to tell you about it.

That was the sentence Maren kept going back to. Not the sorry. Not the sister's face.

Because it meant that on the fourth of September 2015 Ilse Vessel had been holding, alone, at eighty-eight, in a shop with a bad roof, the exact decision that Maren had been holding since the twenty-second of October: what do you do with a thing you cannot give away and cannot destroy and cannot leave lying about for somebody's twelve-year-old to climb up and find.

She had not solved it. She had run out of time in the middle of it, which is what happens, and she had spent her last fortnight putting things where they would be found and hoping that would be enough.

She took the letter through to Ines on the Sunday, and Ines read it at the table with her glasses on and her hand flat beside it, and did not say anything for a while afterwards.

"She never told me she'd written to you," Ines said at last. "And she told me a great deal."

"Did you know she'd said no to me?"

"I knew you'd asked and I knew she'd said no." Ines took her glasses off. "She rang me the same evening. She was in a filthy temper, which with Ilse meant she was upset, and she said, *I have just told that girl there isn't the money for two of us*, and I said, well, there isn't, and she said, *that is not what I mean and you know it is not.*"

"You didn't ask her what she meant."

"I did ask her. She said it was her business." Ines squared the letter up on the table. "And I have spent eleven years being quietly cross with her about it, because I

watched what it did to you both, and I could not for the life of me see why a woman of eighty-eight would push away the only family she had left."

"And now?"

"And now I know why, and I find I am still cross," said Ines Hallow, "which I had not anticipated. She was going to fix it. She had a plan and the plan was decent and it needed about two years and she had eleven months, and nobody gets told how long they have got."

Maren looked at the letter on the table.

"There's a version of this," she said, "where she rings me in 2016. And I come at twenty-five, and the shelf's shut, and she teaches me the shop for four years and dies at ninety-two, and I never know any of it."

"There is."

"I'd have had a completely different life."

"You'd have had four years of her," said Ines, "which you did not have. So I'd not go looking for the moral in it, if I were you, because there isn't one and you'll only make yourself ill."

Maren rang her mother that evening, on the Tuesday instead of the Wednesday, and they talked about the knee for about four minutes.

Then she said, "Mum, I'm staying."

There was a silence on the line long enough that Maren checked the screen.

"Right," said her mother, in a voice that had gone somewhere. "Right. Well."

"You can say something."

"I'm going to say something and then I'm going to go and put the kettle on, because I'd rather not be crying at you down a telephone at my age." Her mother took an audible breath. "She asked me, you know. In about 2016. Whether you were all right, and whether you were angry, and whether she should write."

Maren stood absolutely still.

"And what did you say?"

"I said you were fine and that you'd come round in your own time, because that is what I thought, and because I was cross with her." A pause. "And then a year went by and another one did, and it turned out that neither of you was ever going to be the one, and I have thought about that telephone call approximately once a month for ten years."

"Mum."

"Don't. I'm going to put the kettle on." Her mother's voice steadied by main force. "You'll want the address for the good marmalade, they post it. I'll send it Thursday."

And then, at the end, winding up, in the ordinary way, she said:

"All right, Maren, I'll let you go."

And Maren stood in the back room and heard her name and could not tell which of the two it had been, and said goodnight, and put the phone down, and got on with the boxes.

What to Do With Forty Books

The problem with the shelf was that it could not be solved, and Maren spent the whole of December failing to solve it, in writing, in the back of the seventh ledger, which was by then the only place she thought properly.

She wrote out the options one Sunday and there were four.

One. Leave them where they are. Which meant that in eighteen months a demolition crew would find forty blank books on a high shelf in a condemned building, and forty blank books would go in a skip, and that would be the end of it. She could not decide whether this was the answer or the cowardice, and she wrote underneath it: *this is the only option that requires me to do nothing, which is exactly why I keep coming back to it.*

Two. Destroy them. She had got as far, on the eleventh of December, as standing in the yard with the stove door open and one of them in her hand, and had not been able to do it, and had been extremely annoyed with herself, and had then spent two days working out that the annoyance was misplaced. *I cannot destroy a thing when I do not know what it is. If they are only paper, burning them is theatre. If they are not only paper, burning them is a decision about other people's grandchildren taken by a woman who has had the shelf for nine weeks.*

Three. Give them to somebody. Which was the option that looked most responsible and was, she came to think, the worst of the four. There was nobody to give them to. Ines was seventy-four. Tobias did not want them and had said so plainly. Handing them to anybody else meant handing them the landslide, without the letter, exactly the way it had been handed down three generations of a family who never told each other.

Four. Write it all down and let whoever comes next decide with better information than I had.

She looked at four for a long time.

Then she wrote: *four is not a solution. Four is an admission that this is not soluble in one lifetime, and a refusal to pretend otherwise, and it is what she should have done in 1990 and did not, and it is the only one of these that leaves anybody better off than I was in October.*

So she spent the rest of December on the book.

Not a book off the shelf. A proper one: a hardbound cash book from the stationer in Fenn, the same pattern Ilse had bought for sixty years, and she started it on the fourteenth of December and worked at it every evening after closing.

It had four parts, in the end.

The first was what she knew about how it worked, stated as plainly as she could manage and with the uncertainties marked as uncertainties, which took eleven pages and was the hardest writing she had ever done, because everything she knew she knew from six weeks and twenty-six loans and a dead woman's pencil columns.

The second was the thirteen rules, with what each one had cost to find.

The third was every name and every entry from Ilse's nine pages, copied out, with the fourth column intact, because that was the evidence and it should not be in one place only in a building with a bad roof and a demolition order.

The fourth was the shortest and took the longest. It was addressed to whoever read it, and it said, in the end, what she had spent all month not being able to say to anybody in person:

You will want to do it. That is not a flaw in you and it does not mean you are greedy. Everybody who has ever stood under this shelf has wanted to do it, including the woman who shut it and including me.

Wanting it is not the problem. The problem is that there is no natural place to stop, because the cost is invisible and arrives years later and never looks like a bill. You will not stop because it starts hurting. You will only stop because you decided in advance where to stop, in writing, on a day when nobody was asking you for anything.

*So decide it now, before you take one down. Write the number in the front of this book with the date. And when you get there, stop, even though there will be somebody in front of you that day who deserves it, because there is always

somebody in front of you who deserves it. That is the whole of the difficulty and I have not found any way round it and I do not believe there is one.*

She showed the first draft to Tobias on the sixteenth, at four o'clock, and he read it the way he read everything, twice, and put it down and said nothing for long enough that she began to be uncomfortable.

"It's good," he said. "It's better than good. And there's a thing missing and you're going to hate me for it."

"Go on."

"There's nothing in here about what it's *for*." He put his hand flat on the cover. "Eleven pages on how it works, thirteen rules with what they cost, two hundred and thirty-six entries, and four pages telling whoever gets it that they'll want to do it and mustn't. It reads like a warning notice on a substation."

"It is a warning notice on a substation."

"Then why haven't you burnt it?" said Tobias, mildly.

Maren opened her mouth and did not have anything.

"You wrote a list on the night of the vote," he said. "Things that are not the building. I've not read it and Ines told me it exists because Ines cannot keep anything. And you told her you'd not put the shelf on it, and you'd noticed you'd not put it on it, and you were going to have to think about that."

"She really cannot keep anything."

"She cannot. It's her one flaw and it's load-bearing." Tobias pushed the book back across the table. "So put it in. Not the rules. The other thing. Write down what Dinny Coll's face looked like, and what Ines said about the third line, and the woman who wanted the kitchen without her father in it and came back twice anyway. Because whoever reads this in forty years is going to have exactly the same forty books and none of that, and if all you leave them is thirteen rules and a body count, they'll think it was only ever a machine for hurting people."

"It might be."

"It might be," he agreed. "And you don't think that, and you're the only witness."

So there was a fifth part after all, and it took her until the twenty-eighth, and she called it *What It Was Actually Like*, and it was the longest of the five.

Cato found her at it on the nineteenth, at half five, doing her French badly at the counter while Maren wrote.

"What is that?"

"It's the instructions."

"For what?"

Maren put the pen down.

She had been thinking about this for three weeks and had arrived, that afternoon, at an answer she did not much like and could not improve on.

"Come here," she said.

Cato came and stood at the counter.

"When they knock this down," said Maren, "the books go somewhere. I don't know where yet. And this goes with them, and it explains what they are and what they cost and everything I've been able to work out, and there's a page at the front where whoever's got them writes down how many they're going to do before they start."

"Are you giving them to me?"

"No." Maren said it fast and clearly, because the girl had gone very still. "No. I want to be completely straight with you about this, because you're twelve and you've already had one thing off that shelf you didn't ask permission for."

"That's not fair, I gave it back."

"You did, and I'm not throwing it at you." Maren leaned on the counter. "I'm telling you that I am not giving these to a twelve-year-old, and I'm not giving them to a fifteen-year-old, and I'm not going to write your name in this book, and if I die tomorrow there is a letter with the solicitor in Fenn that says the same thing in language that will annoy everybody."

Cato's jaw was set. "So why are you telling me at all?"

"Because you already know," said Maren. "That's the whole answer. You've known since November and you'll know for the rest of your life, and the only question available to me is whether you find out the rest of it from me, on purpose, in a shop, with the book in front of you, or whether you work it out on your own at twenty-six when there's nobody left to ask."

The stove ticked.

"That's what happened to her, isn't it," said Cato. "Your aunt. Nobody told her."

"Nobody told her, and nobody told her mother, and nobody told her aunt Grete, and it went down three generations of women who were all perfectly capable of

writing a letter." Maren picked the pen back up. "It stops here. That's the only bit of this I'm actually sure about."

Cato considered that with the seriousness of somebody who has been given a real answer and was not entirely expecting one.

"Can I read it?" she said. "Not now. When I'm older, and you say."

"Yes."

"How much older?"

"I don't know," said Maren. "That's honest. I'll have thought about it by then and I'll tell you why, and you'll be allowed to think I'm wrong."

Cato Bril went back to her French.

"You will be wrong," she said, to the exercise book. "You're wrong about the *passé composé* as well."

The Last One

She did one more, on the fourth of March, and it was the only one she ever chose herself.

By March the shop had been open for five months and had made, in that time, a loss of nine hundred and forty pounds, which Tobias had worked out on the back of a menu and had presented to her with the air of a man delivering good news, because Ilse's average had been worse.

The notice to treat had come in February. The date for vacant possession was the thirtieth of June, 2028, which was further off than anybody had expected and which Ines said was the council being decent in the only currency it had.

Maren had taken a room above the tea shop in January, which was two doors and a shared chimney breast away from where she had been sleeping, and which was an arrangement that everybody in Saltmarch had an opinion about and that nobody had asked either of them a single question about, and which Tobias referred to, in front of customers, as **the lodger situation**, entirely deadpan, for four months.

She had not gone back to the technical documentation. She had gone down to three days a week of it in January and had found, to her considerable surprise, that three days a week of proofreading and four days of a bookshop that lost money was a life that worked, and that she had never once in twelve years asked whether the other arrangement had.

Peder Vane came in on the last Wednesday of February to tell her about the relocation grant, which was real and was eleven thousand pounds and which he had argued for in committee and had got.

He told her that, and where the forms were, and that the deadline was September.

Then he stood in the shop with his hands in his pockets and looked at the brown paper on the shelf, as he did every time, and said what he always said, which was nothing.

And Maren, who had been thinking about this since the ninth of December and had made the decision somewhere in the second week of January without noticing, said:

"Peder. Sit down."

The rules said *never for me*, and *never a child*, and *if a man who can decide something asks, the answer is no until the thing is decided.*

The thing was decided. It had been decided on the thirtieth of November by six votes to three, and there was nothing left in this town that Peder Vane could give her and nothing left that she could ask him for, and Maren had checked that four separate ways over three months because she was the sort of person who checked things.

He did not ask. She had known he would not, and had not required it.

"The fourth of March, 1990," she said. "Your father asked for a Sunday afternoon and my aunt said no, and she was right, and he knew she was right within about a mile of walking home."

Peder Vane had gone very still on the stool by the local history.

"He's been dead nine years," he said.

"I know. I'm not offering it to him." Maren stood up. "You were sixteen and you were at that lunch too, and you've been carrying a hole where four hours used to be since 1990, and you told me so in this shop in November and then you went away and voted the way you'd always said you would."

"Maren."

"I'm going up the ladder now," she said, "and if you'd rather I didn't, say so before I get to the third rung, because after that I'm not going to ask you again and I'm not going to bring it up in ten years' time."

She got to the third rung.

He did not say anything.

He was in the back room for thirty-one minutes, which was the longest of any of them.

Maren sat at the counter and did not sell anything to anybody, and thought about rule five, which she had written on the back of a council notice on a Saturday evening in October and had not broken and was not breaking now, and about rule seven, which said that the day she wanted something out of it was the day she stopped.

She examined that one carefully, because it was the one that mattered and because she had four minutes and nothing else to do.

Did she want something out of this.

The honest answer took a while and was not flattering. She wanted Peder Vane to think well of her, which was a small vanity and which she noted. She wanted, more than that, to have done one that she had chosen: twenty-six had come in through the door and asked and she had said yes or no, and not one of them had been hers, and there was something in her that had wanted, since about January, to find out what it was like to give a thing away on purpose rather than on request.

That was not a good reason. She wrote it down afterwards under rule fourteen so that nobody could say she had not seen it.

But it was not the whole of it either, and the rest of it was this: a woman had stood at this counter in 1990 and said no to a man for the right reasons and had taken the whole cost of that on herself, and had then spent thirty-five years being, in that family, the woman who had refused. That was the only version of Ilse Vessel that Peder Vane had ever been given.

Maren had read a letter in the fourth ledger and knew there was another one.

She could not hand him the letter. But she could hand him four hours in March of 1990, and she was, she thought, the only person alive who both could and knew why it mattered, and there was going to be nobody else after her.

At thirty-one minutes the door opened.

Peder Vane came out with the book held against his chest with both arms, the way you hold something in a wind, which she had now seen five people do and which she had stopped finding remarkable.

He did not say anything at all. He put the book on the counter, very carefully, and shook her hand, and went out, and the bell did its two notes, and Maren did not see him again until the middle of April, when he came in and bought a road atlas

and said, "That was a good afternoon. Thank you," and nothing else, ever, for the rest of the time they knew each other, which was nineteen years.

Afterwards, she wrote it in the ledger, third column, in the ordinary way.

4.iii.26 / P. Vane / a Sunday afternoon in March 1990, four hours, entire /

The fourth column stayed empty for eleven weeks.

It arrived on the twenty-third of May, on the harbour road, on an ordinary Tuesday, while she was carrying two bags of shopping and thinking about nothing in particular.

She stopped walking.

She stood outside the chandlery, at the corner where a grey cat with no name had turned round every time for six summers, and went looking for it, deliberately, the way you press a tooth.

It was not there.

Eleven years of a small hard thing she had carried up and down stairs and into other people's kitchens and had taken out and examined perhaps a thousand times: *she said no, and she never explained, and after that it was easier not to go.* The shape of it. The particular temperature of it. The way it had sat.

She could state the facts. She rang in 2015 and asked and was refused and did not come back for eleven years and her aunt died. All present, all correct, all completely flat, like a road she recognised yard by yard and could not walk in her head.

The anger had gone through the net.

Maren stood on the harbour road with two bags of shopping for what a woman going past afterwards described as an unusually long time, and did not know whether to laugh.

Because here was the thing, and she turned it over the whole way home and for a good deal of the summer afterwards, and never entirely got to the bottom of it.

She could not tell whether the shelf had taken it, or whether she had simply stopped being angry.

Nine months. A letter in the fourth ledger. Her mother crying at a telephone. A hundred and ninety coats in a church hall. Any of those would have done it on their own, given time, and time is what the whole business is made of.

There was no way to check. There had never been any way to check. That was the design, and she had known it since October, and she had gone on believing that this once, on the last one, she would be able to tell.

She wrote the fourth column that evening, at the counter, with the shop shut and the light on over the till.

4.iii.26 / P. Vane / a Sunday afternoon in March 1990, four hours, entire / eleven years of being angry with her, possibly. See note.

And then, on the blank page at the back, under the thirteen rules, in the book that was going to go wherever the forty books went:

Fourteen, and it is the last one I have found and I suspect it is the last one there is.

You will not get a receipt. Not for the ones you paid and not for the ones you were let off. On the final entry in this ledger I cannot tell you whether the shelf took my anger or whether nine months in this town did it, and I have been trying since May, and I am not going to be able to.

I have decided to be glad about it. That is a decision and not a discovery, and I am writing it down as a decision so that nobody after me mistakes it for evidence.

She could not tell either. I am nearly sure of that now. Fifty-four years and nine ruled pages and she could not tell, and she went on writing the fourth column anyway, every time, for a woman she would never meet.

Do the same. Write it down even when you do not know. Especially then.

There is one more thing that belongs here, and it belongs here because it is the answer to the question Ines asked on the telephone on the night of the vote, and because Maren did not work it out for nearly a year.

How do you keep a room without the building.

The answer turned out to be extremely dull, which is how she knew it was the right one.

In the September of 2027, nine months before vacant possession, the parish council let the old net loft on the east pier for a peppercorn rent to a company limited by guarantee with four directors, of whom one was a retired teacher, one ran a tea shop, one was seventy-five, and one had a bad knee and had moved up from two hundred miles away in the April and had views about the marmalade.

It had a hole in the roof. Dinny Coll did the flashing.

There is nothing magical about the net loft and there never has been. It has a stove, and a chair by it, and a long table, and about four thousand books priced at two pounds fifty by a rule that nobody has ever proposed changing. People go in and stand about for twenty minutes and say nothing much and go home feeling better, and it loses roughly eleven hundred pounds a year, and it has never once in its history had a high shelf.

Things that are not the building, Maren had written, on the night she lost.

She had been right about all of them, and it had still taken her eleven months and four directors and a lease to move a room two hundred yards along a pier, and that is the whole of what anybody in this story ever found out about the question.

The shop stayed open until the thirtieth of June, 2028, and on the last afternoon there were forty-one people in it, which Ines counted, because Ines counted.

But that is a different story, and this one ends in May, on the harbour road, outside the chandlery, with a woman standing still holding two bags of shopping in the middle of an ordinary Tuesday, looking for something and failing to find it, and going home.

A Word Before You Go

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With thanks, Maren Ashcroft

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About the Author

Maren Ashcroft writes quiet fantasy about small places and the things people mislay. She lives on a coast where the boat does not always run.